

SEAMLESS RAIL, METRO, REGIONAL CONNECTIVITY PLANNED

PM Modi to unveil Noida Airport tomorrow; will ease load on IGIA

OUR CORRESPONDENT

GREATER NOIDA: Prime Minister Narendra Modi will inaugurate the Noida International Airport on March 28, marking a significant milestone in India's aviation expansion.

The Prime Minister will tour the airport terminal before formally inaugurating the facility at noon and addressing a gathering.

Located in Jewar in the National Capital Region (NCR), the Noida International Airport is expected to complement Indira Gandhi International Airport and ease passenger traffic. Together, the two airports are set to position the Delhi-NCR region as a major aviation hub.

Developed at an estimated cost of Rs 11,200 crore under a public-private partnership model, Phase I of the project will have an initial capacity to handle 12 million passengers



A view of the newly constructed Noida International Airport, on Thursday

PIC/PTI

annually, scalable up to 70 million passengers upon full completion. The airport features a 3,900-metre runway capable of handling wide-body aircraft, along with advanced navigation systems and all-weather operational capabilities.

A key highlight of the

project is its integrated cargo ecosystem, including a multi-level cargo hub with an initial capacity of over 2.5 lakh metric tonnes annually. The airport will also house a dedicated 40-acre Maintenance, Repair and Overhaul (MRO) facility.

Strategically located near

the Yamuna Expressway, the airport is designed as a multimodal transport hub with seamless connectivity through rail, metro and regional transit systems. Officials said the airport has been designed with a focus on sustainability, incorporating energy-efficient sys-

tems and environmentally responsible practices.

They added that the project is expected to boost regional connectivity, strengthen trade and logistics, generate employment opportunities, and enhance India's position in global aviation.

CLOSER LOOK

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Airport to generate steady income & boost urban dev

DIPIKA KIROLA

GREATER NOIDA: The upcoming Noida International Airport is set to emerge as a key economic driver for Noida, Greater Noida and the Yamuna Expressway Industrial Development Authority (YEIDA), boosting real estate and industrial investment while creating sustained revenue streams for urban development.

Officials said the airport has already triggered a sharp rise in property prices and accelerated industrial activity across the region, with its long-term financial impact expected to be even more significant. A special purpose vehicle, Noida International Airport Limited, has been formed by the Government of Uttar Pradesh along with the three development authorities to manage the project.

Under the equity structure, the state government and Noida Authority hold 37.5 per cent stake each, while Greater Noida and YEIDA hold 12.5 per cent each. So far, over Rs 4,406 crore has been spent on land acquisition, jointly borne

'This investment is expected to begin yielding returns from the 6th year of commercial ops, when revenue sharing commences'

by the government and the authorities. This investment is expected to begin yielding returns from the sixth year of commercial operations, when revenue sharing commences. "The project was awarded to Zurich Airport International AG, which secured the bid by offering a per-passenger fee of Rs 400.97 — among the highest globally. This means every domestic and international passenger will directly contribute to the revenue pool, which will be distributed among stakeholders based on their equity," a senior official said.

Authorities believe this steady income will become a financial backbone, particularly as their traditional revenue source — land allotment — continues to shrink due to

limited availability of land. At the same time, rapid population growth has increased pressure on urban infrastructure and civic amenities, widening the gap between income and expenditure.

Passenger traffic is projected at 5–6 million annually in the initial phase, with estimates suggesting it could rise to as high as 70 million passengers per year by 2040. Officials said such growth would significantly strengthen the financial capacity of the authorities, enabling sustained investment in infrastructure and public services.

"With a fixed per-ticket revenue model, the airport will ensure a predictable income stream. From the sixth year of operations, this will begin contributing substantially to the authorities' finances," the official added. Experts noted that beyond aviation, the airport is expected to catalyse economic activity across sectors — from logistics and warehousing to hospitality and manufacturing — reinforcing its role as a long-term growth engine for the NCR region.

Woman stabbed by cousin over money dispute

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A 29-year-old woman was allegedly stabbed by her cousin at her residence in east Delhi's Mayur Vihar following a dispute over money, officials said on Thursday.

The incident took place around 9.45 pm on Wednesday when the accused, Aslam, reached the house of the victim, Afsana, a resident of Trilokpur, and allegedly started abusing her while demanding money he claimed was owed to him, they added. "When the woman refused to pay, Aslam allegedly threatened to kill her and attacked her with a knife, inflicting a grievous injury on her neck with the intent to murder," police said.

Following the assault, Afsana rang up Aslam's mother, who rushed to the spot and took the injured woman to Lal Bahadur Shastri Hospital, where she was admitted for treatment. On receiving information regarding the admission of an injured woman, the police team rushed to the hospital, where Afsana was found conscious and fit to give her statement, the police said.

Based on her statement, an attempt to murder case was registered at the Mayur Vihar police station. The accused was arrested and the weapon used in the offence was recovered. The woman is currently under medical observation.



'They hugged him, then stabbed him': Teen killed, 3 minors apprehended in Dayalpur

NEW DELHI:

A 16-year-old boy was allegedly stabbed to death near his home in north-east Delhi's Dayalpur area on Wednesday night, with police stating that the attack may have been linked to alleged bullying involving one of the accused.

Three juveniles, aged between 13 and 17, have been apprehended in connection with the murder, officials said on Thursday.

According to the police, the incident occurred when a group of youths called the teenager out of his house late at night. Shortly afterwards, family members found him lying unconscious nearby and rushed him to Jag Pravesh Chandra Hospital, where doctors declared him brought dead.

During the preliminary investigation, police identified

Delhi Police solve blind murder case; four minors apprehended

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police has solved the blind murder of a 23-year-old man in outer Delhi's Bawana area, apprehending four juveniles who allegedly planned and executed the crime following a prior dispute.

The victim, identified as Vicky, a resident of Holambi Khurd, was found dead with his throat slit near Sector-5, UER-II on January 28, two days after he went missing. A case was registered at Narela

Industrial Area police station.

Police said the case initially had no clues, but a breakthrough came when the victim was last seen with one of the accused. Acting on a tip-off on March 24, all four suspects, aged 17, were apprehended.

During interrogation, they confessed, citing a previous scuffle as the motive. Police said the murder was premeditated, and the body was dumped to avoid detection.

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three juveniles as the attackers and registered a case at Dayalpur police station. The accused were subsequently apprehended, and a knife believed to have been used in the crime was recovered from them.

During questioning, the

juveniles told investigators that the victim had allegedly been bullying one of them, which they claimed led to the fatal assault. Police said they are verifying these claims as part of the ongoing probe.

The victim's mother, however, disputed the allegation and said her son had no history of conflict. She alleged that the attackers were known to him and had deliberately lured him out before carrying out the assault.

"They first hugged him and then stabbed him," the victim's mother said, rejecting bullying claims and insisting he had no disputes.

The body has been sent to Guru Teg Bahadur Hospital for post-mortem as police record statements, gather evidence and continue investigation into the motive.

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NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police booked a gas agency owner for allegedly hoarding and black marketing LPG cylinders in outer Delhi's Rahnola area, seizing 459 cylinders during a raid, an official said on Thursday.

The accused, identified as Susheel Kumar Singhal, owner of HP Balaji Gas Agency, was found allegedly involved in illegal storage and misuse of commercial LPG cylinders, the police said in a statement.

According to police, the operation was carried out following specific intelligence inputs regarding large-scale hoarding amid concerns over a possible LPG shortage.

"A coordinated raid was conducted at the gas agency located on Nilothi Road in Rahnola, where 459 empty LPG cylinders of Indane and

Bharat Petroleum were recovered," a senior police officer said. The seized cylinders included 284 Indane gas cylinders and 175 Bharat Petroleum cylinders, police said, adding that a food supply officer was called to the scene to initiate action. A case has been registered under Section 7 of the Essential Commodities Act, and relevant provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and further investigation is underway.

Police said the gas agency owner hoarded commercial LPG cylinders, diverting them from legal channels. He allegedly exploited demand-supply gaps to sell at inflated prices. The stock was disguised as regular inventory. Recovered cylinders were handed over to a Hindustan Petroleum Gas representative.

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JNU approves 246 promotions

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Jawaharlal Nehru University has approved 246 faculty promotions under the Career Advancement Scheme (CAS) between February 2022 and February 2026, one of the largest such exercises in its history.

Promotions span all levels, with 82 at Assistant Professor (Stage-2) and 75 at Professor (Stage-5), alongside representation across categories. Parallely, over 400 recruitment interviews led to 219 faculty selections cleared by the Executive Council — 110 Associate Professors, 73 Assistant Professors and 36 Professors.

Officials said the drive addressed long-pending backlogs since 2006, ensured transparency, and aimed to strengthen academic capacity and inclusivity.

Active member of Rohit Chaudhary gang caught with firearms

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police has arrested a member of the Rohit Chaudhary gang with a cache of illegal firearms and ammunition, an official said on Thursday. The accused, Pard-eep Gulati, a resident of Kalkaji, was arrested based on a tip-off about his gang activities, he said.

Police said the accused was allegedly storing weapons at his residence on behalf of another gang member for use in serious crimes, including extortion and violent offences.

Four firearms -- three semi-automatic pistols and one country-made pistol -- along with 22 live cartridges were

recovered from his possession, the official said, adding that the weapons were kept in a bag.

"The operation was carried out after surveillance and verification of inputs regarding illegal arms supply and planned criminal activities linked to the gang," the officer added.

During interrogation, Gulati revealed that he was a close associate of Arvind Gupta alias Disilva, an active member of the Rohit Chaudhary gang, and received the weapons around a month ago for safekeeping.

A case has been registered, and further investigation is underway, police said.

Proclaimed offender absconding in '22 murder case nabbed: Cops

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A proclaimed offender who was absconding in a murder case lodged against him in 2022 was arrested in Delhi's Alipur area, police said on Thursday.

The accused, identified as Anil (29), was apprehended from Sheela Colony in Gurugram. He had been declared a proclaimed offender in May 2023 by a Rohini court in connection with the case.

Acting on a tip-off, a team conducted a raid at a farmhouse in Sheela Colony on Tuesday and nabbed the accused. During interrogation, he disclosed his involvement in the murder of Nazir on September 23,



2022, they said.

He, along with his associates Ranjit, Dinesh and Ramu, allegedly assaulted the victim after consuming liquor, leading to his death, the police said.

"The accused and his associates later disposed of the body near Nale Wala Road in Alipur using a tempo. Police

“He, along with his associates Ranjit, Dinesh and Ramu, assaulted the victim after consuming liquor, leading to his death”

had earlier arrested Ranjit and Ramu, while Anil and another accused, Dinesh, had been absconding since the incident," the officer said.

Anil, a native of Alipur, had shifted to Gurugram to evade arrest and was living there with his family. Further investigation is underway.

NAJAFGARH

154 vehicles booked for tinted windows; 4 impounded: Cops

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A total of 154 vehicles were prosecuted and four impounded during a special drive against tinted windows in Delhi's Najafgarh area, police said on Thursday.

The action was carried out on Wednesday under the jurisdiction of the Najafgarh traffic circle amid rising concerns over the increasing use of black films on car windows, they said.

According to police, tinted windows pose serious safety concerns, particularly for women, and may also be used to conceal criminal activities.

"A special drive was



“A special drive was launched to curb this growing menace and ensure strict compliance with traffic rules”

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ing menace and ensure strict compliance with traffic rules," a senior police officer said.

During the drive, 154 vehicles were booked under relevant sections of the Central Motor Vehicles Rules, 1989, for having tinted windows. The films put on the vehicle windows were removed on the spot, the officer said.

Additionally, four vehicles were impounded for violations such as driving without a licence, defective number plates and misbehaviour, according to police.

"The majority of the vehicles booked included popular models such as Mahindra Thar and Scorpio, among other cars," a police statement said.

Woman used social media to trap victims, extort money; 2 held

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: The Crime Branch of Delhi Police has arrested a woman and her accomplice for allegedly running an organised honey-trapping and extortion racket, officials said.

The case came to light following an anonymous tip-off to the Crime Branch. The accomplice has been identified as Yashdev Singh Chauhan (44), a resident of New Usmanpur. Police said he allegedly posed as an advocate but was in fact working as a clerk with a lawyer at Karkardooma Courts.

According to investigators, the accused misused criminal law provisions by filing multiple cases against victims to extort money through negotiated settlements. A case has been registered at Mehrauli police station under Sections 385, 389 and 34 of the IPC.

Police said the woman systematically targeted individuals, often initiating contact through social media on the pretext of offering professional services. In one instance, a retired Army captain alleged



that she approached him to promote his novels, induced financial transactions, and later created disputes before filing a criminal complaint against him.

An FIR registered in 2021 at Mehrauli police station under serious charges, including rape and criminal intimidation, was subsequently challenged by the complainant. The Supreme Court quashed the FIR on February 25, 2025, observing that the proceedings amounted to an abuse of the process of law.

Police said the woman filed nine FIRs across Delhi, including rape and molestation cases. She used intermediaries for settlements. Devices with audio evidence were seized, and voice samples sent for forensic analysis.



A delegation led by Prof Ioannis visited Guru Gobind Singh Indraprastha University under Erasmus+, discussing academic exchange, joint research, int'l collaboration with V-C Verma

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ASHTAMI OUTREACH IN GOVT SCHOOLS

CM gifts wheels of hope to 1,100 girls

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Marking the occasion of Durga Ashtami, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Thursday distributed bicycles to 1,100 schoolgirls who recently entered Class 10 in government schools in Shalimar Bagh. The event, held at Sarvodaya Vidyalaya in Pitampura, saw emotional scenes as several students expressed gratitude after receiving the bicycles.

Addressing the gathering, Gupta described daughters as embodiments of divinity and emphasised the need to support their education and empowerment. “Navratri is not just about worship, but also about reaffirming respect for girls and committing to their empowerment,” she said, adding, “Our daughters are like goddesses.”

Highlighting provisions in the Delhi Budget 2026-27, the Chief Minister spoke about the ‘Lakshmi Batiya Yojana’, aimed at providing financial support to girls from birth through graduation. “By the time she completes her education, each girl will receive around Rs 1.25 lakh, helping her move forward with confidence and independence,” Gupta said.

She also addressed the issue of school dropouts caused by commuting challenges, announcing a major bicycle distribution scheme. “Feedback showed that lack of transport disrupts studies. To address this, we will provide bicycles to all girls entering Class 9 every year,” she said, noting that around 1.3 lakh students will benefit annually. Clarifying the current distribution, she added that the bicycles given to Class 10 students were part of her personal initiative. Interacting with students, she said, “You know how to ride, right? If not, learn soon.



CM Rekha Gupta poses with a young girl during ‘Kanya Pujan’ on the occasion of ‘Durga Ashtami’, at Sarvodaya Vidyalaya in Shalimar Bagh, New Delhi

“Aim high, make your parents, society, and the nation proud — CM REKHA

Now you’ll complete your education on your own strength.”

Hitting back at critics, Gupta said, “Calling such schemes into question is shameful,” adding that “questioning initiatives meant for daughters reflects a regrettable mindset.”

The Chief Minister also announced additional measures to promote women’s safety and self-reliance. She said 1,000 new

auto permits will be issued to women under the ‘Pink Auto’ scheme, creating employment opportunities. In the health sector, she announced free blood screening for newborns to detect 56 genetic disorders, with the government bearing the entire cost. Encouraging the students, Gupta said, “Aim high, make your parents, society, and the nation proud,” assuring them that the government stands firmly behind their aspirations. The event concluded on an emotional note as students shared their dreams and thanked the Chief Minister, with many saying the bicycles would help them attend school regularly and pursue their goals with greater confidence.

‘Sheesh Mahal’ row snowballs; CM targets Kejriwal

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A political storm has intensified in Delhi after a video linked to the alleged “Sheesh Mahal” surfaced, with Chief Minister Rekha Gupta and PWD Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh Verma launching sharp attacks on former Chief Minister Arvind Kejriwal over alleged misuse of public funds.

Reacting to the video, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the truth could no longer be hidden. “Now the truth cannot be hidden. What was kept behind

curtains for years is now before the people of Delhi,” she said. She alleged that the bungalow symbolised “corruption, arrogance and betrayal of public trust,” adding that it was “not just a building, but a living proof of moral decline.”

Gupta claimed that a project initially estimated at around Rs 8 crore escalated to nearly Rs 62 crore, raising serious questions about financial irregularities. She pointed to the presence of “50 ACs, expensive interiors, foreign coffee machines and high-end equipment,” alleg-

ing misuse of taxpayer money. “When people were struggling during the pandemic, those in power were busy building a palace for themselves,” she said.

Calling it a “black chapter of corruption,” Gupta urged citizens to watch the video and judge for themselves. She also assured strict action, stating that “no one found guilty will be spared,” and that a detailed probe is underway through the Public Accounts Committee (PAC).

Meanwhile, PWD Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh Verma

released a video walkthrough of the 6 Flagstaff Road bungalow, describing it as a factual account for public scrutiny. “Delhi was promised politics of simplicity and honesty... What is visible here today is completely different from those promises,” he said.

Highlighting luxury features, Verma noted installations such as a modular kitchen worth Rs.1.5 crore, chandeliers up to Rs.88 lakh, curtains worth Rs.95 lakh and nearly 50 air conditioners. “Nearly 50 ACs in one bungalow, all maintained on

public money. The people of Delhi deserve to know how their hard-earned money is being spent,” he said.

He also questioned the timing of the expenditure, stating, “When Delhi was struggling during COVID... prioritising such work raises serious questions about governance.”

Emphasising accountability, Verma added, “This is not about politics, it is about public money... every rupee must be justified,” asserting that the video allows citizens to see the reality for themselves.

Work underway to restore supply after Chandrawal WTP disruption

NEW DELHI: Water supply restoration efforts are underway on a war footing after a technical fault at the Chandrawal Water Treatment Plant (WTP) disrupted supply in several parts of the city.

Officials said the disruption was caused by damage to a 600 mm backwash pipeline on March 22, which led to water-logging in the pump house. As a result, all electrical and mechanical (E&M) equipment had to be shut down, impacting water distribution in affected areas.

Repair work was initiated immediately, and the damaged pipeline has since been fixed on an emergency basis. However, officials noted that technical snags in pump sets further delayed full restoration. One 18 MGD and one 11 MGD pump-set developed issues even after initial repairs.

At present, pump sets with capacities of 18 MGD and 11 MGD are operational, with around 29 MGD of water being pumped. An additional 11 MGD pumpset has been powered and is currently running on no-load, and is expected to be brought into operation shortly.

Kejriwal says voters feel ‘cheated’ by BJP



OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: AAP supremo Arvind Kejriwal on Thursday hit out at the BJP government in Delhi and said the people of the Capital are feeling “cheated” for voting for the saffron party.

The remarks follow a resident of Rajinder Nagar flagging a water-related issue, claiming there has been no water in his area for the past four days.

Responding to the post, Kejriwal claimed the ruling party has failed to deliver on governance and focused on criticising him instead.

“Delhiites are feeling cheated after voting for them (BJP),” Kejriwal said.

Reacting to Delhi BJP sharpening its attack on him by sharing a video that

labels him “Delhi’s Rehman Dakaai” while highlighting alleged extravagance in the controversial “Sheesh Mahal” bungalow, Kejriwal said the ruling party has failed to deliver on governance and has instead focused on criticising him.

“The BJP came to power by attacking Kejriwal, and it continues doing so instead of addressing public issues,” Kejriwal said.

Delhi PWD Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh recently released a video titled ‘Dhurandhar 3’, in which he is seen touring the 6, Flagstaff Road bungalow that served as Kejriwal’s official residence as the chief minister from 2015 to 2024.

The video shows various features of the bungalow, including a jacuzzi and chandeliers, while alleging excessive expenditure on its renovation.

“They (BJP) came to power by hurling abuses at me, and for the next four years, they will do nothing but keep hurling abuses at me. They neither know how to run a government, nor do they have any desire to do so,” Kejriwal said.

Commercial LPG quota jumps from 20% to 50%

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government has increased the allocation of commercial LPG cylinders from 20 per cent to 50 per cent of average daily consumption, raising the supply from 1,800 to 4,500 cylinders (19 kg equivalent) per day. The move follows directives from the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas and aims to ensure uninterrupted supply across key sectors.

Announcing the decision, Food and Supplies Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa said the enhanced allocation will benefit essential services, hotels, restau-



rants, industries, and migrant workers. He assured residents that the situation remains stable and urged people not to pay heed to rumours of shortages.

“We thank the visionary leadership of PM Narendra Modi Ji for this timely increase to 50 per cent allocation. Thanks to his proactive support, Delhi-

ites will face no hurdles in commercial LPG supply,” Sirsa said.

Under the revised distribution policy, the 4,500 cylinders are being allocated across seven priority categories. The largest share, 3,375 cylinders (75 per cent), has been earmarked for hotels, restaurants, dhabas, food processing units, and dairies. Essential services such as hospitals, educational institutions, transport hubs, and government establishments will receive 225 cylinders each (5 per cent each category).

Migrant workers have also been provided relief, with a dedicated allocation of 684 small (5 kg) cylinders per day

under a protected quota.

To prevent hoarding and black marketing, the government has deployed 70 enforcement teams across the city. Officials said strict action will be taken against violators under relevant laws, including the Essential Commodities Act.

“The situation is fully under control. Supplies are normal and flowing smoothly. I request people not to believe or spread baseless rumours,” Sirsa added.

The government said it is working in close coordination with oil marketing companies and monitoring supply regularly to ensure fairness and transparency in distribution.

City Briefs

NDMC PLANS TO SET UP 8 STPs

NEW DELHI: The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) has invited bids for setting up eight decentralised sewage treatment plants (STPs) under a public-private partnership (PPP) model, with the aim to use the treated water for horticulture, fountains and water bodies. This would help reduce the dependence on fresh water to maintain the city’s green cover. According to the Request for Proposal (RFP) issued on Tuesday, the civic body plans to install STPs with capacities ranging from 500 to 1,000 kilolitres per day (KLD) at key locations, including Shanti Path, Lodhi Garden, Sanjay Lake Park and Talkatora Garden.

SWITCH OFF NON ESSENTIAL LIGHTING DURING EARTH HOUR ON SAT: DISCOMS

NEW DELHI: City power discoms have urged Delhiites to participate in Earth Hour on Saturday by turning off non-essential electrical appliances between 8.30 pm and 9.30 pm to promote a sustainable environment. BSES discoms BRPL and BYPL have joined the event promoted by WWF-India. This year’s initiative is themed “Give an Hour for Earth,” calling on citizens to dedicate one hour to the planet and inspire lasting change. “As a proud partner of WWF-India, BSES has urged its around 54 lakh consumers and 2.25 crore residents across South, West, East and Central Delhi to participate in this global movement,” the discom said in a statement. Last year, Delhi saved 269 MW during Earth Hour. From homes and markets to offices and public spaces, the city will unite in turning off non-essential lights and appliances during this hour in a collective act that emphasises a shared commitment to sustainability. Earth Hour 2026 also marks two decades of a movement that has grown from a symbolic switch-off in Sydney in 2007 into a defining global call for climate action across more than 190 countries.

PWD WAIVES road restoration charges to fast-track PNG rollout

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Public Works Department (PWD), to ensure faster laying of PNG pipelines, has decided to approve road-cutting permission within 24 hours from receiving the request, an official order said on Thursday.

The PWD, which is the main road owning agency in the national capital, has also waived off road restoration charges for three months, in a fresh order issued.

“It is further directed that permission for road cutting for laying of Indraprastha Gas Limited (IGL) pipelines shall be accorded within 24 hours of receipt of a complete request, along with directions to commence the work immediately,” the order said.

The road restoration charges applicable for laying of IGL pipelines for PNG connections are hereby waived for a period of three months – up to June 30, 2026, it added.

The road restoration charge is levied by the road-owning agency on any service provider cutting a road or footpath to lay down the lines.

IGL has been directed to undertake the work on priority, deploying adequate manpower and resources.

STRICT ACTION FOR VIOLATIONS

No reels in class: GOVT to schools

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government has directed all schools to ensure that students, teachers and staff do not create reels or short videos during school hours, emphasising that academic work, discipline or dignity of institutions should not be hampered by such activities.

In a circular issued on Wednesday, the Directorate of Education (DoE) said it has come to notice that short videos are being created on school premises for entertainment and school heads should strictly prohibit such practices during class hours.

The directive underlined that any activity disrupting the teaching-learning process or distracting students must be prohibited, decorum and dignity of institutions should be maintained and the focus should remain on education.

However, the department said content related to “academic, cultural or awareness themes may be created” with prior approval of the competent authority and under a teacher’s supervision, while ensuring that academic activities are not interrupted and students’ safety and privacy are safeguarded. It also

MOST URGENT

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said no inappropriate, non-academic or promotional material should be recorded on school premises. “All school heads have been instructed to disseminate these directions among staff and students and ensure strict compliance, warning that any violation of the instructions will be viewed seriously,” it stated and marked the matter as ‘most urgent’.

Align courses with global needs: L-G Sandhu to nursing college

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Thursday asked the Nursing College at Hindu Rao Hospital and Medical College to align its curriculum with international requirements, stressing the need to prepare a skilled workforce to meet global healthcare demands.

During a visit to the hospital, the Lt Governor said that nursing institutions in Delhi and across India should explore tie-ups with foreign colleges and train a certain number of additional students according to curricula suggested by international partners, an official statement said.

He emphasised that such partnerships could also include funding support from foreign institutions, while Indian colleges ensure a trained workforce for overseas healthcare systems.

Highlighting India’s demographic advantage, Sandhu said the country’s young population, with a median age of around 28–30 years, could be effectively trained to meet the growing global demand for



caregivers, especially in ageing societies.

He noted that countries in the Global North are seeing an increasing need for nurses and paramedical staff due to ageing populations, leading to a widening demand-supply gap.

“This presents a significant opportunity for India to train and supply skilled healthcare professionals to meet global requirements,” he said.

The Lt Governor added that partnerships with foreign institutions would help Indian students learn languages, clinical practices and skills in line with international standards, improving their job prospects.

He also said such trained professionals could work abroad for a fixed period and return with valuable experience, which would benefit India’s domestic healthcare system. He offered to help build international linkages and share global best practices, calling the initiative a “win-win” that would create jobs for Indian youth while addressing healthcare workforce shortages abroad.

PWD plans AI-enabled cams to track crime, potholes in Delhi

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government is planning a major overhaul of its CCTV surveillance network, with a focus on integrating artificial intelligence (AI)-based analytics to enhance both public safety and civic management, officials said on Thursday.

In the past few years, the Public Works Department (PWD) has installed around 2.8 lakh CCTV cameras in two phases. However, over the years, several of those cameras have outlived their capacity and will be replaced, they said.

“To strengthen its CCTV

network, PWD plans to conduct a detailed assessment, which will include identifying existing deficiencies, covering gaps, storage limitations, network bottlenecks, and operational issues. We plan to hire a company for which a tender has been floated,” a senior government official said.

PWD minister Parvesh Sahib Singh had earlier directed the officials to come up with a plan to replace the obsolete cameras, and while doing so, also plan ahead, including the use of cameras for civic revamp.

As per the plan, “the consultants will set up a modern

command and control centre incorporating advanced AI-based analytics which can detect mob lynching, potholes, garbage dumping, street monitoring, and other relevant analytics.”

The PWD has planned that the new network will also have facial recognition and Automatic Number Plate Recognition (ANPR) systems incorporated into the monitoring mechanism, which help in taking steps to reduce pollution.

In some areas, there are multiple agencies installing the CCTV cameras, so PWD has to make that assessment and avoid duplication.

ORDER UNDERLINES A PUNISHMENT OF UP TO THREE YEARS' IMPRISONMENT

Census officer asking offensive question to face action: Order

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: An officer who intentionally puts “any offensive or improper question” during the Census 2027 shall face a punishment with imprisonment which may extend to three years upon conviction, the latest circular issued by the Registrar General of India said.

In a note circulated to all states, Registrar General & Census Commissioner Mritunjay Kumar Narayan listed the penalties prescribed under Section 11 of the Census Act, 1948, which range from a Rs 1,000 penalty to three years’ imprisonment, or both, upon conviction under certain categories.

HIGHLIGHTS

» In a note circulated to all states, Registrar General & Census Commissioner Mritunjay Kumar Narayan listed the penalties prescribed under Section 11 of the Census Act, 1948, which range from a Rs 1,000 penalty to three years’ imprisonment, or both,

upon conviction under certain categories

» The officer who ‘neglects to use reasonable diligence’ in performing any duty during the census, disobeys any order or hinders or obstructs another person in performing any such duty shall also face the same punishment, if convicted

The order underlines a punishment of up to three years’

imprisonment upon conviction for any census officer who “intentionally puts any offen-

sive or improper question” or knowingly makes “any false return” or, without the previous sanction of the central government or the state government, discloses any information which was received during the census.

The officer who “neglects to use reasonable diligence” in performing any duty during the census, disobeys any order or hinders or obstructs another person in performing any such duty shall also face the same punishment, if convicted.

“Any sorter, compiler or other member of the census staff who removes, secretes, damages or destroys any census docu-

ments or deals with any census document in a manner likely to falsify or impair the tabulation of census results” shall also be liable for imprisonment upon conviction, it said.

The Union Cabinet has approved Rs 11,718 crore for conducting the Census of India, 2027, which would include the caste enumeration for the first time. The 16th Census since Independence will be a fully digital exercise and will offer citizens the option of self-enumeration. The decadal exercise, scheduled for 2021, was postponed due to the COVID-19 pandemic across the country. WITH AGENCY INPUTS

MP: 10 dead and 31 injured in bus-pick up vehicle collision

CHHINDWARA: Ten persons were killed and 31 injured, including three to four critically, in a head-on collision between a bus returning from a public function attended by the chief minister and a pick-up vehicle in Madhya Pradesh’s Chhindwara on Thursday evening, officials said.

Chief Minister Mohan Yadav expressed grief over the incident and announced compensation of Rs 4 lakh each for the kin of the deceased and Rs 1 lakh for those injured. Treatment of all injured persons would be provided free of cost, the CM announced.

The incident took place near Simaria on Nagpur road, some 25 kilometres from district headquarters, Superintendent of Police Ajay Pandey told PTI.

“Six men, three women and

‘Six men, three women and a child were killed in the accident’

a child were killed in the accident,” he added.

Chhindwara Collector Harendra Narayan told PTI that 31 persons have been injured as per doctors.

“Of the injured, three to four are critical. One of them has been rushed to a hospital in Nagpur in neighbouring Maharashtra for advanced treatment,” Narayan informed.

The bus was carrying more than 40 passengers at the time of the accident, Kotwali station house officer Ashish Kumar added.

The injured were taken to

the district hospital and other medical facilities in the vicinity in ambulances and other vehicles, officials said.

In a post on X, CM Yadav announced compensation details and said the accident was heart-rending.

“I pray to the Almighty to grant peace to the departed souls and wish speedy recovery to the injured,” he stated.

Officials have been directed to ensure proper treatment of the injured and to send teams of doctors from Jabalpur to Chhindwara and Nagpur, the CM said in his message.

Yadav also directed Chhindwara guardian minister Rakesh Singh to alter his schedule and reach the district.

A control room has been set up in the health department in Bhopal to monitor treatment of the injured, he added. AGENCIES

Top Court tags multiple pleas challenging UP Gangsters Act, refers them to 3-judge bench

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court has ordered clubbing of all pending petitions challenging the constitutional validity of certain provisions of the Uttar Pradesh Gangsters and Anti-Social Activities (Prevention) Act, 1986 for adjudication by a

three-judge bench.

The law was enacted to combat organised crime, dacoity, and anti-social activities threatening public order and safety in Uttar Pradesh.

A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and justices

Joyimalya Bagchi and Vipul M Pancholi ordered the tagging of all related matters and also made the Centre a party to the proceedings. During the proceedings, senior advocate Shoeb Alam, representing the petitioners, addressed concerns

regarding the overlapping of cases across different benches.

He said that while a coordinate bench comprising justices JB Pardiwala and KV Viswanathan is currently examining Section 111 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), which deals with

organised crime, the present plea challenged the provisions of the UP Gangsters Act.

Responding to suggestions of “bench hunting,” the senior lawyer said, “There is no question of any bench hunting on our part. If anything, it requires

an explanation from the other side as to how the present matter was listed here while connected cases were being heard elsewhere.”

Alam also said that a previous dismissal of a petition related to the Act in July 2025

did not constitute a legal precedent or “merger,” as it was a simple dismissal without a detailed adjudication on merits.

The CJ said that the Uttar Pradesh law is part of a broader legislative trend across India aimed at tackling structured

criminal networks.

“There are similar legislative frameworks across states. Provisions dealing with organised crime have been enacted in states such as Maharashtra (MCOCA), Gujarat (GUJ-TOC), and Delhi,” he said. PTI

From Page 1

Iran and US

by roiling the world economy with its stranglehold on the Strait of Hormuz — raising prices at the pump for drivers, prices in the grocery store for families and costs for businesses the world over.

Short of a negotiated solution, the US would need a dramatic escalation to end Iran’s attacks and restore the free flow of goods through the strait, where 20% of all traded oil and natural gas is transported in peacetime. Iran rejected a ceasefire proposal put forth by the US, while putting forth its own demands.

President Donald Trump, speaking at the start of a Thursday cabinet meeting, said he wanted to “set the record straight” that he isn’t the one pushing for a deal. “They’re begging to make a deal, not me,” Trump said.

Trump envoy Steve Witkoff confirmed the US has presented a 15-point “action list” to Iran, delivered through Pakistan as a framework for a possible peace deal. Witkoff indicated there’s a “strong possibility” an agreement can be reached.

Trump vowed to strike Iran’s power plants if it doesn’t fully reopen the strait — and his new deadline for that looms this weekend, when the war will also mark a month. But a Gulf Arab bloc said Thursday that Iran is now exacting tolls from ships to ensure their safe passage through the waterway.

Iran has been blocking ships from the strait that it perceives as linked to the US and Israeli war effort, while letting through a trickle of others.

Jasem Mohamed al-Budaiwi, secretary-general of the Gulf Cooperation Council, a bloc of six Gulf Arab nations, said Iran was charging for safe passage.

The Fars and Tasnim news agencies, both close to Iran’s paramilitary Revolutionary Guard, quoted lawmaker Mohammadreza Rezaei Kouchi as saying that parliament was working to formalise that process and that it was “natural” for ships to pay for it.

Lloyd’s List Intelligence called it a “de facto toll booth regime,” saying that at least two vessels have paid in yuan, China’s currency.

Iran’s grip on the strait and relentless attacks on Gulf regional energy infrastructure have sent oil prices skyrocketing and concerns of a global energy crisis surging.

Brent crude, the international standard, traded at \$104 Thursday, up more than 40% from Feb. 28, when the war started. Germany’s Defense Minister Boris Pistorius called it a “catastrophe” for the world’s economies.

Israel said it killed the head of Iranian Revolutionary Guard’s navy, Commodore Alireza Tangsiri, and the country’s naval intelligence chief, Behnam

Rezaei.

Israeli Defence Minister Israel Katz said Tangsiri was responsible for bombing operations that have blocked ships from crossing the Strait of Hormuz. Rezaei had “central knowledge authority in maritime intelligence,” the Israeli military said. Iran did not immediately acknowledge the killings.

Using Pakistan as an intermediary, Washington has delivered to Iran a 15-point ceasefire proposal, which includes the reopening of the Strait of Hormuz.

A day after saying Iran wants to cut a deal, Trump posted on social media Thursday that Tehran needs to “get serious soon” on negotiating an end to the war “before it is too late, because once that happens there is NO TURNING BACK, and it won’t be pretty!”

He did not elaborate, but said Iran should be negotiating because “they have been militarily obliterated, with zero chance of a comeback.”

Iran’s Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi said in an interview on state TV that his government has not engaged in talks to end the war and does not plan to.

Araghchi said the US had tried to send messages to Iran through other nations, “but that is not a conversation nor a negotiation.”

Egypt is also acting as a go-between, according to Egyptian Foreign Minister Badr Abdelatty, who said Thursday that his country sees a desire from both sides “for calm, for the exploration of negotiations.”

Press TV, the English-language broadcaster on Iranian state television, said Iran has its own five-point proposal, which included reparations and recognition of its sovereignty over the Strait of Hormuz.

Meanwhile, a group of ships, including the USS Tripoli, drew closer to the Mideast with some 2,500 Marines. Also, at least 1,000 paratroopers from the 82nd Airborne — trained to land in hostile territory to secure key territory and airfields — have been ordered to the region.

Israel said it carried out a wave of attacks targeting Iranian infrastructure early Thursday, and air defences were heard in Tehran. Heavy strikes were also reported around Isfahan, home to a major Iranian air base and other military sites, as well as one of the nuclear sites bombed by the US during the 12-day war in June.

Loud booms could be heard across Israel as it was repeatedly targeted by barrages from Iran. Israel’s Magen David Adom emergency service said a man in his 30s was killed in the area of Nahariya, the country’s northernmost coastal city. In the United Arab Emirates, two people were reported killed by shrapnel from a missile interception over Abu Dhabi.

Since the war began, more than 1,900 people have been killed in Iran, Deputy Health Minister Ali Jafarian told Al Jazeera.

Eighteen people have died in Israel, while three Israeli soldiers have also been killed in Leba-

non. At least 13 American troops have been killed.

Authorities said nearly 1,100 people have died in Lebanon, where Israel has targeted the Iran-backed Hezbollah militant group, which has fired into Israel.

Indian among

“The incident has resulted in the deaths of two individuals of Pakistani and Indian nationality,” it said, adding that three others, including an Emirati, a Jordanian and an Indian, sustained injuries ranging from serious to moderate.

The Indian embassy said it “expresses its deepest condolences at the tragic demise of an Indian national due to falling debris in Abu Dhabi today.”

“The Embassy is closely coordinating with the UAE authorities to render all possible support and assistance,” it posted on X.

The Ministry of Defence stated that its air defences have been countering repeated missile and drone threats from Iran. On March 26 alone, the systems intercepted 15 ballistic missiles and 11 unmanned aerial vehicles.

With the latest casualties, the death toll has risen to 11, Gulf News reported. The ministry said that since the start of the attacks, UAE forces have engaged 372 ballistic missiles, 15 cruise missiles and 1,826 UAVs.

It added that two armed forces personnel and a Moroccan civilian contractor were also killed, along with eight civilians of various nationalities. A total of 169 people have been injured in the attacks so far.

The ministry said it remains fully prepared to counter any threats to the country’s security and stability. AGENCIES

Govt assures 60 days

month of uninterrupted supply, while “additional procurement” is “being finalised”.

This comes amid concerns over shipments through the Strait of Hormuz, a key route for LPG imports.

The ministry said, “The claim that PNG is being pushed because LPG is running out is misinformation. LPG supply is secure.”

Parallely, state-owned oil marketing companies also said there is no shortage of petrol, diesel or liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) and supplies remain stable.

Stating that all retail fuel outlets have enough supplies, the ministry called upon citizens not to be “misled by a deliberately mischievous, coordinated campaign of misinformation that is being carried out to spread unjustified panic.”

Separately, Indian Oil Corporation (IOC), Bharat Petroleum Corporation Ltd (BPCL) and Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Ltd (HPCL) put out posts to say their petrol pumps were

operating normally and there was no shortage of any fuels.

India, the world’s fourth-largest refiner and fifth-largest exporter of petroleum products, has structurally assured domestic fuel availability and continues to supply refined fuels to over 150 countries, the ministry statement said.

LPG supplies are also sufficient, it said, with domestic production increased and import requirements reduced. Additional cargoes have been secured from multiple countries, ensuring steady availability.

The government warned that misleading social media posts and fabricated claims of shortages or emergency measures were being spread to create unnecessary anxiety, and said action will be taken against those responsible.

The ministry said all one lakh-plus retail fuel outlets across the country are open and dispensing fuel without interruption. “Not a single outlet has been asked to ration supply.”

Across the world, countries are dealing with price increases, rationing, odd-even vehicle restrictions, and forced station closures. Few have declared a ‘National Energy Emergency’.

“India does not feel the need for any such measures,” it said. “While other nations are rationing, there is no shortage of supplies in India.”

Calling panic buying as “isolated instances” at “select pumps,” it said “they were driven by deliberate misinformation spread by certain videos in social media.”

“Despite the surge in demand on such pumps, fuel was dispensed to all the consumers and oil company depots have been operational through the night to ramp up supplies,” it said.

The government said, “Oil companies are successfully delivering over 50 lakh cylinders every day. Cylinder demand had gone up to 89 lakh cylinders due to panic ordering by consumers and has now come down to 50 lakh cylinders again..”

Commercial cylinder allocations have been raised to 50 per cent in consultation with state governments to avoid hoarding or black marketing.

On natural gas, it said India produces 92 million standard cubic meters per day of natural gas domestically out of a total daily requirement of 191 mmscmd, making India far less import-dependent on gas than on LPG. And so piped natural gas (PNG) as an alternative to LPG is being considered. WITH AGENCY INPUTS

Nayara hikes

Nayara, which operates 6,967 of India’s 102,075 petrol pumps, has now revised retail rates to Rs 91.31 per litre for petrol and Rs

91.31 for diesel. In a statement, the company cited “unprecedented challenges” due to supply disruptions but did not specify the extent of the hike. It said operations remain stable, adding, “We are fully focused on meeting India’s energy needs by

maintaining a consistent supply of high-quality fuels.”

Meanwhile, Jio-bp, which runs 2,185 outlets, has not revised prices despite reported losses. State-owned retailers, controlling about 90 per cent of the market, have also kept prices unchanged.

Sources said private retailers receive no compensation for holding prices, leaving them with limited options as losses mount. MPOST

PM to meet

Modi had also told the Rajya Sabha that the effects of the conflict could persist and urged collective efforts to sustain India’s growth.

States under the Model Code of Conduct due to ongoing elections will not attend, but their Chief Secretaries will be briefed separately through the Cabinet Secretariat.

Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah confirmed his participation, stating there is no shortage of petroleum products. “There are adequate stocks of petrol and LPG cylinders, but people are queuing up based on rumours,” he said, warning that continued panic could force temporary closure of petrol pumps.

The Centre is also expected to review contingency planning to maintain stability if global conditions worsen.

India, 4 others

Araghchi made it clear that vessels associated with Iran’s adversaries would not be granted access. “We are in a state of war. The region is a war zone, and there is no reason to allow the ships of our enemies and their allies to pass through,” he said, adding that the route “remains open to others.”

He also dismissed the possibility of negotiations with the United States, saying no talks were underway despite outreach from regional foreign ministers. “International guarantees are not 100 per cent reliable,” he said, asserting that Iran’s own measures would deter future conflict.

The situation has drawn global attention, with US President Donald Trump warning Tehran of consequences if the waterway is not fully reopened.

India has stepped up diplomatic engagement in recent weeks, aiming to ease tensions and ensure uninterrupted energy flows, amid concerns over fuel and fertiliser security if the disruption continues.

Andhra: Bus catches fire

Flames rapidly spread, trapping passengers inside and leaving several bodies severely charred.

Home Minister Vangalapudi Anitha confirmed that all 13 victims died due to burns. “There were 41 people in the bus at the time of the accident

and all the 13 deceased persons were burnt to death,” she said. She added that the vehicle, operated by Harikrishna Travels, had valid licence and insurance until December 2026.

Police said preliminary findings suggest the bus veered into the wrong lane before crashing into the truck. Markapuram in-charge Superintendent of Police V Harshavardhan Raju said the impact occurred near the truck’s diesel tank, which contributed to the intensity of the fire. “It is visible that the bus hit the truck,” he told reporters, noting that people travelling in the tipper were also injured.

According to investigators, the blaze was further intensified when the bus battery caught fire. Officials said five passengers died in the front section while eight others were killed in the rear. The driver’s claim that the steering wheel had malfunctioned will be examined as part of the ongoing investigation.

Three of the injured are reported to be in critical condition, while others are undergoing treatment in nearby hospitals. Survivors described scenes of panic, confusion and desperate attempts to escape as smoke and flames filled the bus within moments of the crash.

A woman passenger recalled the chaos from her hospital bed, saying she and two companions had been asleep when the accident occurred. “We were sleeping and fell from our seats. By the time we realised why we had fallen, there was smoke,” she said, adding that a boy travelling with them had feared they would not survive. “Two of us are alive, but there is no trace of the boy.”

Another young survivor, suffering from burn injuries, said he had little recollection of the sequence of events. “I don’t know what happened. I was sleeping. I fell onto the road. There were flames on my body,” he said, struggling to speak.

Passengers described waking up to darkness, heat and thick smoke as people scrambled toward exits. One man seated in the front row said he managed to escape through a window. “I didn’t realise anything until the fire reached me. I couldn’t breathe and had inhaled a lot of smoke. Everything was dark,” he said, adding that he could not find anyone else after jumping out.

Another survivor said passengers were trampling over each other in a bid to get out. “We didn’t know where the exit door was. I squeezed out through a window,” he said.

A male passenger seated in the middle of the bus said he was awake at the time of the accident and was able to assist others. “I was checking my phone. I opened the emergency door and helped a woman out,” he said.

The aftermath presented grim scenes, with several completely burnt bodies lying on the road before being moved to ambulances. In some cases, the severity of the fire left remains barely recognisable.

President Droupadi Murmu and Prime Minister Narendra

Modi expressed grief over the loss of lives. In a message, the President said she was “deeply saddened” and extended condolences to the bereaved families while wishing a speedy recovery for the injured. The Prime Minister announced an ex gratia of Rs 2 lakh for the next of kin of each deceased and Rs 50,000 for those injured, calling the incident “tragic.”

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu held a teleconference with officials and directed them to ensure the best possible medical care for the injured and compensation for victims’ families. He also ordered a detailed inquiry into the accident. Telangana Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy asked state officials to gather information about those affected, as several passengers were believed to be from Telangana.

Authorities continue to investigate the exact cause of the crash while rescue and relief operations have concluded.

SC panel urges

It warned that the absence of recognition may hinder access to identity documents and welfare benefits meant for transgender persons.

The revised definition, the committee said, appears to cover only those with specified congenital variations or individuals who have undergone surgical transition. This, it indicated, could leave out people who identify differently from their assigned gender at birth and may pursue gender-affirming care such as hormone therapy or counselling.

Privacy concerns were also raised. The amendment requires medical institutions conducting gender-affirming procedures to share details with district authorities, potentially placing sensitive personal information on official records. The introduction of a medical certification process, where district magistrates issue identity certificates based on inputs from designated medical authorities, was flagged for possible risks to confidentiality.

In addition, the panel questioned the necessity of new penal provisions, noting that several offences listed in the amendment are already addressed under existing criminal laws, even though penalties have been increased for acts such as forced identity, abduction and exploitation.

The committee observed that removing self-identification could be inconsistent with the Supreme Court’s 2014 NALSA judgment, which recognised the right to determine one’s own gender. It recommended that any changes to the 2019 law be preceded by broader consultations with transgender communities and stakeholders.

The advisory body was set up by a bench of Justices JB Pardiwala and R Mahadevan while hearing a case involving the dismissal of a transgender teacher, with a mandate to examine barriers in employment, healthcare and public services.



“Mental health is a fundamental part of our overall well-being. Let us also work collectively to create environments where conversations around mental health become more mainstream.”

Shri. Narendra Modi
Hon'ble Prime Minister



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INDIA'S NAXAL DEADLINE

Forces launch final assault, Centre prepares blueprint post March 31

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Security forces deployed in the anti-Naxal operations grid have launched a mega operation to neutralise the remaining armed Maoist cadres with less than a week remaining until the national deadline of March 31 to end left wing extremism in the country. Official sources told the news agency that the Centre is also preparing an "operations and development" blueprint which is expected to include an announcement for withdrawal of about five Central Armed Police Forces (CAPFs) battalions from these regions and the launch of multiple welfare schemes.

About three to four CoBRA units of the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) are being moved from Chhattisgarh to Jharkhand to undertake a special operation in the Saranda

Key Points

» 'About three to four CoBRA units of the CRPF are being moved from Chhattisgarh to Jharkhand to undertake a special operation'

» - The sources indicated that a cross-border operation involving Maharashtra, Chhattisgarh, Telangana and Odisha is also in the works

» - 'Misir Besra alias Bhaskar is stated to be



based in Jharkhand and CoBRA teams are searching for him and his associates'

forests of West Singhbhum district, they said.

Similarly, the sources said that teams from CRPF, BSF and Indo-Tibetan Border Police (ITBP) are being "re-located" in Chhattisgarh's Bastar area with the specific aim of engaging armed Maoist cadres in a gunbattle or forcing their surrender.

The sources indicated that a cross-border operation involv-

ing Maharashtra, Chhattisgarh, Telangana and Odisha is also in the works.

"The plan is to ensure 100 per cent neutralisation of armed Naxals by March 31, a deadline announced by Union Home Minister Amit Shah. This would either by engaging in encounters or getting effected surrenders.

"Some large operations are being undertaken in these last

5-6 days of the countdown," a top CAPF commander told the news agency.

Security forces are still tracking about 130-150 armed cadres, two central committee members of the outlawed CPI (Maoist) and some other divisional-rank operatives.

Misir Besra alias Bhaskar is stated to be based in Jharkhand and CoBRA teams are searching for him and his associates.

Rammanna, also known as Ganapathi or Laxman Rao is reportedly in touch with Telangana Police and may surrender by March 31, according to officials.

Another officer said that about three battalions of the Border Security Force (BSF), along with a sector office headed by a DIG-rank officer, are expected to withdraw from Koraput district and adjoining areas of Odisha.

The sector office could relocate to Kandhamal district in the state and the three battalions will either move for border guarding duties or to Manipur, as the situation may warrant.

Some CAPF battalions from Chhattisgarh will also be withdrawn. An announcement in this context is expected on March 31. The state police and the Chhattisgarh DRG will take over the CAPF camps, the second officer added.

MHA report: 29 new ITBP outposts set up along China border

Similar work has been done on the India-Nepal and India-Bhutan borders as well, annual report said

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Indo-Tibetan Border Police (ITBP) has strengthened its presence with 29 new border outposts along the India-China border since 2020 as part of a broader security build-up along the 3,488 km border, according to a report of the Ministry of Home Affairs.

The new border outposts (BOPs) span altitudes ranging from 9,000 feet to 18,750 feet across the Western, Middle, and Eastern sectors along the Himalayas, from the Karakoram Pass in Ladakh to Jachep La in Arunachal Pradesh, the report for 2024-25, released on Wednesday, said, adding the ITBP is manning a total of 209 BOPs.

The number of ITBP-managed BOPs was 180, according to the ministry's earlier report for 2020-21.

The increase in the number of BOPs comes in the wake of the 2020 clash between Indian

TAKEAWAYS

» The number of ITBP-managed BOPs was 180, according to the ministry's earlier report for 2020-21

» - 'ITBP had conducted 4,503 patrols along the Indo-China border from April to December 2024 to keep strict vigil'

and Chinese troops in the Galwan Valley which marked the most serious military conflict between the two sides in decades.

The ITBP had conducted 4,503 patrols along the Indo-China border from April to December 2024 to keep strict vigil, the latest report said.

"ITBP ensured security of the border and remained vigilant during heightened security scenarios along the Indo-China border," it said.

The ministry created the Department of Border Management in January 2024 to focus on issues related to the management of international land and coastal borders.

The department works to strengthen border policing and guarding, the creation of infrastructure such as roads, fencing, flood lighting, and border outposts (BOPs)/ company operating bases (COBs) at the borders, and the implementation of the Border Area Development Programme (BADDP).

The push is also being given on the India-Pakistan and India-Bangladesh borders, where the ministry has approved the construction of BOPs, the report said.

"Out of 509 Composite BOPs, 383 Composite BOPs are to be constructed along the India-Bangladesh Border," the annual report said.

Similar work has been done on the India-Nepal and India-Bhutan borders as well, it said.

People of Punjab have made up mind to bring BJP to power: CM Saini

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini said that Congress and the Aam Aadmi Party have an internal alliance, but the people of Punjab have decided to bring the BJP to power.

Saini was speaking to the media after addressing a gathering at Gurdwara Sri Nanakshar Sahib in Ludhiana district of Punjab.

Alleging a covert alliance between Congress and the Aam Aadmi Party, he said that during elections, both parties support each other but no success.

Saini said that Prime Minister Narendra Modi has resolved to make India a developed nation by the year 2047, and Punjab will not lag behind in this mission. He added that the brave people of this state made significant contributions to India's freedom struggle, and Prime Minister Modi is continuously working towards fulfilling the vision they had for the country and the state.

He said that Punjab was once a number one state in terms of development, but in recent times, the kind of politics practiced has pushed the youth into the trap of drugs, and the state has lagged behind in development.

Meanwhile, the Nayab Singh Saini government for the first time since it came to power conducted a major reshuffle of 63 IAS and HCS

Saini government for the first time since it came to power conducted a major reshuffle of 63 IAS and HCS officers

officers.

Providing information in this regard, a government spokesperson stated that Amit Kumar Agrawal has been appointed as Member Secretary, Kurukshetra Development Board, Kurukshetra, in addition to his present duties. Similarly, Geeta Bharti has been appointed as Commissioner, Hisar Division; Ravi Prakash Gupta as Commissioner, Gurugram Division and will continue as Secretary, Haryana Urban Estate Department; Narhari Singh Banger as Managing Director, CONFED; Satyender Duhan as Director, Skill Development & Industrial Training and Additional Secretary to Government, Haryana; Satbir Singh as Director, Fire Services, Haryana and Chief Executive Officer, Ayushman Bharat Haryana Health Protection Authority; and Vandana Disodia (IAS, 2018) as Additional Secretary to Government, Haryana, Home-I and Home-II Department and Managing Director, Haryana Scheduled Castes Finance & Development Corporation.

CBI searches Mumbai in Reliance Telecom fraud case

NEW DELHI: The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) searched some places in Mumbai. The CBI is investigating an alleged bank fraud case involving Reliance Telecom.

Earlier, the CBI has filed a case against Reliance Telecom, its directors Satish Seth, Gautam B. Doshi, and some unknown people for cheating and conspiracy.

According to the officials, the State Bank of India had complained to the CBI that Reliance Telecom had cheated them. The company had taken Rs 114.98 crore, which was not its money. The State Bank of India was a part of 11 banks that had given a loan of Rs 735 crore to Reliance Telecom.

MPOST

SAYS BEIJUNG IN VEILED DIG AT US 'India & China's growth built on hard work, not due to foreign generosity'

NEW DELHI: India and China achieved "remarkable" development in the last few decades because of their "hard work" not due to the "generosity" of others, Chinese ambassador Xu Feihong said on Thursday, rejecting claims that outside powers fuelled Beijing's economic rise.

Xu's remarks are largely seen as a rebuttal to recent remarks by US Deputy Secretary of State Christopher Landau, who recently characterised past US economic support for China as a "mistake" that Washington will avoid repeating with New Delhi.

In a thinly veiled dig at the US, the Chinese ambassador, speaking at an event, without naming any country, said cer-

tain elements do not want to see China and India live in harmony and "hype up" the so-called China threat, hoping to profit from the "discord".

"In recent decades, both China and India have achieved remarkable development. These achievements are built on the hard work and wisdom of our own people, supported by global cooperation, and are by no means the result of others' generosity," the envoy said.

He was speaking at the 14th China-India Youth Dialogue.

In an address at the Raisina Dialogue earlier this month, Landau said that the US will not repeat the mistake of providing India the same type of economic advantages it gave China that helped Beijing become a

key competitor of the US.

Xu said India and China should achieve development through their own efforts, while actively pursuing mutually beneficial cooperation and supporting each other's success.

"China and India are neighbours that cannot be moved apart. It should be the right choice for both sides to be good-neighbourly friends and partners that help each other succeed, and realise the Dragon-Elephant Tango," he said.

"However, some people are unwilling to see China and India live in harmony. They deliberately amplify our differences, hype up the so-called 'China threat,' and hope to profit from discord between our two countries," Xu said.

AGENCIES

Mumbai based kingpin of Myanmar cyber slavery network arrested

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) arrested a Mumbai-based accused, Sunil Nellathu Ramakrishnan, aka Krish, for his alleged role as a key kingpin in a transnational human trafficking and cyber fraud network operating out of Myanmar, the officials informed on Thursday.

According to officials, the accused was involved in luring unsuspecting Indian citizens with promises of lucrative jobs in Thailand. Victims were flown from Delhi to Bangkok and then illegally transported to scam compounds in Myanmar's Myawaddy region, including the notorious KK Park. In fact, the inves-

tigations revealed that victims were forced to work in cyber fraud centres, carrying out scams such as "digital arrest" frauds, online romance scams and cryptocurrency investment frauds targeting people across the world, including India. Survivors have reported being subjected to confinement, intimidation, and physical and psychological abuse under strict surveillance.

Meanwhile, the probe gained momentum after several Indian nationals managed to escape these facilities in 2025 and were repatriated from Thailand.

Their testimonies helped investigators map the trafficking routes and uncover the operational structure of these syndicates.

MARKS INDEPENDENCE DAY IN DELHI

Bangladesh highlights ties with India and democratic transition

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Bangladesh's High Commissioner to India, M Riaz Hamidullah, on Wednesday underscored the depth of Dhaka's relationship with New Delhi and reaffirmed commitment to closer cooperation as Bangladesh celebrated its 56th Independence and National Day in the Indian capital, in the presence of Minister of State for External Affairs Kirti Vardhan Singh.

Speaking at a reception at Bangladesh House, Hamidullah paid tribute to those who

died in the 1971 Liberation War, recalling the sacrifices made during the nine-month conflict and acknowledging India's role, including the contribution of 1,668 Indian soldiers who lost their lives.

Highlighting shared history and cultural ties, he said the relationship between the two countries extends beyond geography to a "deeper human and cultural mosaic", referencing figures such as Rabindranath Tagore and Kazi Nazrul Islam.

The envoy also pointed to recent political developments in Bangladesh, noting that 76



Minister of State for External Affairs Kirti Vardhan Singh with Bangladesh's High Commissioner to India, M Riaz Hamidullah

MPOST

million voters participated in what he described as a peace-

ful and participatory electoral process.

He said the new government, led by Prime Minister Tarique Rahman, has committed to advancing relations with India based on "dignity, equality, mutual trust and respect".

Quoting Rahman's message to Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Hamidullah said Bangladesh places "high importance" on ties with India and sees significant potential for cooperation that benefits people in both countries.

On economic engagement,

the High Commissioner noted that bilateral goods trade stands at about \$12 billion, while broader economic interactions could reach \$28-30 billion.

He stressed that both countries, with young populations and shared development aspirations, must address sensitive issues through dialogue, including trade, security and resource sharing.

Hamidullah concluded by calling for an "interdependent" future, urging both nations to build on common values of democracy, stability and prosperity.

MAJOR CRACKDOWN

NCB destroys over 400 kg of narcotics worth Rs 212 cr

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: In a major step towards a drug-free India, the Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB), Delhi Zonal Unit, has disposed of over 400 kg of seized narcotic drugs and psychotropic substances, with an estimated value of Rs 212.21 crore, the NCB informed on Thursday.

The large-scale disposal was carried out under the supervision of the Regional Drugs Disposal Committee and the High-Level Drugs Disposal Committee, covering 39 pre-trial and post-trial cases. Officials said the process was conducted in strict compliance with legal procedures, ensuring transparency and adherence to established protocols.

The destroyed contraband included 121.698 kg of ganja, 29.566 kg of cocaine, 13.834 kg of heroin, 27.366 kg of charas, and 122 kg of alprazolam tablets. Additionally, 395 bottles of codeine-based cough syrup, along with significant quantities of ephedrine, pseudoephedrine and smaller amounts of amphetamine and other narcotics, were also disposed of.



Officials described the operation as a major step in preventing the re-entry of seized drugs into illegal circulation. The action underscores the agency's continued efforts to dismantle drug trafficking networks and curb substance abuse.

The exercise is part of the government's broader push under the 'Nasha Mukta Bharat Abhiyan', aimed at eliminating drug abuse and trafficking across the country. Authorities said such operations not only strengthen enforcement but also send a clear message to traffickers that agencies remain vigilant.

VIT scores big in QS World University Rankings by subject 2026

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: VIT has achieved a significant milestone in the recently published QS World University Rankings by

Subject 2026, with a record number of subjects breaking into the top 200 ranking in the World. With 17 subjects ranked globally, VIT is rapidly closing the gap with global education leaders through major improvements in Engineering, Technology, Sciences, Management, Agriculture & Design.

Engineering & Technology remains the forte of VIT and is ranked 119 on the World, moving up 23 places from last year where it was ranked 142.

In Engineering & Technology, VIT has moved to the 6th rank in India. In Mathematics, it has secured the 5th rank.

In the subjects of Computer Science & Information Systems, Electrical & Electronics, and Data Science & Artificial Intelligence, Mechanical, Aeronautical & Manufacturing VIT has achieved the 6th, 7th and 8th ranks respectively in India.

Ram Navami celebrated with processions, prayers and communal harmony across India

Special prayers and community feasts were organised in several states

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Decked up with colourful flowers and lights, temples across the country resonated with prayers while the streets came alive with vibrant processions as Ram Navami was celebrated with religious fervour on Thursday.

Special prayers and community feasts were organised in several states, with devotees thronging temples since early morning amid strong security arrangements put in place by authorities to prevent any untoward incident.

In different parts of the country, elaborate processions -- referred to as 'shobha yatra' -- were taken out with devotees chanting 'Jai Shri Ram', carrying saffron flags and participating in cultural performances on the occasion to celebrate the birth anniversary of Lord Ram.

In Uttar Pradesh's Ayodhya, considered to be the birthplace of Lord Ram, the main celebration will be held



Devotees perform 'aarti' during the 'Ram Navami' festival, at Ramchandra Temple in Jaipur, Thursday

PTI

Highlights

» In Uttar Pradesh's Ayodhya, considered to be the birthplace of Lord Ram, the main celebration will be held on Friday

» In a display of communal harmony in Jammu and Kashmir's Srinagar, Muslims joined Hindus at the Raghunath Mandir, which hosted its first Ram Navami pooja in 36 years

on Friday, with over a lakh devotees expected at the Ram Janmabhoomi temple.

Temple trust member Anil

Mishra told a news agency that the main attraction will be the Surya Tilak ceremony, during which sun rays will illu-

WAR OF WORDS AHEAD OF POLLS

Vijayan attacks Rahul, calls Cong BJP’s ‘B-team’; Congress hits back

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KOCHI/KOLLAM: Rahul Gandhi’s claim that the LDF and BJP are colluding in the April 9 Assembly polls in Kerala drew a sharp rebuttal on Thursday from Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan, who said the Congress leader lacks even the insight of a regional leader.

A day after Rahul claimed that the alleged lack of action by central agencies in various corruption cases against Vijayan was proof of “collusion” between the LDF and the BJP, the veteran Marxist, speaking to the media in Kothamangalam in Ernakulam district, accused the Gandhi scion and his party of being the BJP’s ‘B-team’.

Enraged by Vijayan’s retort against Rahul, the Congress hit back at the chief minister, accusing him of targeting its leader to get into the good books of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union Home Minister Amit Shah.

The allegations and counterclaims by leaders of the two major fronts—the Congress-led



Kerala Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan during a rally ahead of the state Assembly elections, in Kochi, Thursday PTI

UDF and the CPI(M)-headed LDF—further escalated the political contest as the campaign for the Assembly polls reached its peak in the state.

Rahul launched a scathing attack on the Left at a rally organised by the Congress in Kozhikode on

Wednesday.

Hitting back at the Congress leader, Vijayan said despite being a national political figure, “he does not learn from experience” and accused him and his party of being the BJP’s ‘B-team’.

“Though he (Rahul) is a

national leader, the fact is that he lacks the understanding that a regional leader has. He does not try to understand anything clearly. Also, he does not learn from experience.

“These are not traits that befit a political leader. How can there be so much decline

HIGHLIGHTS

- » Congress hit back at the chief minister, accusing him of targeting its leader to get into the good books of Prime Minister Modi and Amit Shah
- » The CM said that in Delhi, Rahul and the Congress had sought the arrest of AAP leader Arvind Kejriwal in a liquor policy corruption case
- » Vijayan also pointed out that the Congress, instead of joining forces with the AAP to defeat the BJP in Delhi, opposed Kejriwal’s party, leading to the saffron party’s victory there
- » Vijayan also reacted to Rahul’s allegation that corruption cases against him were going nowhere

in an important figure in the Congress? All this shows that Rahul and the Congress in India are the B-team of the BJP,” the CPI(M) politburo member said.

Vijayan also reacted to Rahul’s allegation that corruption cases against him were going nowhere, while Opposition leaders across the country were being targeted and cases registered against them for opposing the BJP, which he said was an indication of collusion between the LDF and the BJP.

The CM said that in Delhi, Rahul and the Congress had sought the arrest of Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) leader Arvind Kejriwal in a liquor policy corruption case. But, Kejriwal was later acquitted and it was a “blow to the face” of the BJP and the Congress, including Rahul, he said.

He also pointed out that the Congress, instead of joining forces with the AAP to defeat the BJP in Delhi, opposed Kejriwal’s party, leading to the saffron party’s victory there.

Assam polls: 722 candidates in fray after 67 withdraw nomination

The state elections will be held on April 9

OUR CORRESPONDENT

GUWAHATI: A total of 722 candidates are left in the fray for the Assam Assembly elections after 67 nominees pulled out of the contest on the last day of withdrawal on Thursday, officials said.

Among the candidates who withdrew their nominations are National Peoples’ Party’s (NPP) Md Aminul Islam (Mankachar seat), who had resigned from the AIUDF recently, four of the Autonomous State Demand Committee (ASDC) and one leader of the Gondwana Ganatantra Party. The remaining ones are all independents.

The four ASDC members are Kamal Singh Bey (Bokajan), Mandal Enghi (Howraghat), Gulson Bey (Diphu) and Anjoshi Terang (Haflong), officials said.

A total of 815 candidates had filed 1,389 nomination papers across 126 constituencies.

Following scrutiny, 789 candidates were found eligible.

Among the prominent candidates in the fray are Chief Minister Himanta Biswa



Polling officials undergo training on the operation of EVM and VVPAT units ahead of the Assam Assembly elections, in Sonitpur, Thursday PTI

Sarma, state Congress president Gaurav Gogoi, Leader of the Opposition Debabrata Saikia of the Congress, AIUDF chief Badruddin Ajmal, Assembly Speaker Biswajit Daimary and several cabinet ministers.

The elections will be held on April 9, and counting will take place on May 4.

Meanwhile, attacking the Opposition, Assam BJP president Dilip Saikia on Thursday alleged that the Congress slogan of a ‘Natun Bor Asom’ (new Greater Assam) is a “dangerous conspiracy” aimed at protect-

ing the rights of ‘Miyas’ at the cost of indigenous people.

He asserted that the saffron party was taking both visible and subtle measures to safeguard the state and its people, and said these efforts would be conveyed to the new generation of voters.

Saikia also said the updated, final National Register of Citizens (NRC) is not acceptable to the BJP in its current format and maintained that it will be rectified by a BJP government if it returns to power after the April 9 state polls.

‘Sonia Gandhi responding well to treatment’

NEW DELHI: Senior Congress leader Sonia Gandhi is responding well to treatment for a systemic infection and continues to remain under medical supervision at Sir Ganga Ram Hospital, the hospital authorities said on Thursday.

Chairman Dr Ajay Swaroop said that Gandhi, who was admitted on the night of March 24, is being treated with antibiotics for systemic infection and is responding well to the therapy.

MPPOST

Akhilesh Yadav targets BJP over LPG shortage, cites long queues across UP

BISWAJEET BANERJEE



Samajwadi Party President Akhilesh Yadav during a press conference, in Lucknow, Thursday PTI

LUCKNOW: Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav on Thursday attacked the Bharatiya Janata Party government in Uttar Pradesh over reports of LPG shortages, alleging that the administration has failed to ensure smooth supply and has pushed people into long queues for basic fuel needs.

Addressing a press conference in Lucknow, Yadav referred to the long lines outside gas agencies and petrol

pumps in several parts of the state and said the situation reflects poor planning by the government. He remarked that standing in queues has become a recurring reality for people under BJP rule, extending from cooking gas to petrol.

The SP chief claimed that the government did not make adequate preparations to handle the demand for LPG, leading to supply disruptions in multiple districts. He alleged that even domestic cylinders were not being delivered properly and questioned the quality and quantity being supplied to consumers.

‘Why govt in a hurry to amend women’s quota law’

Must call all-party meeting after current round of Assembly polls: Kharge

NEW DELHI: Congress chief Mallikarjun Kharge wrote to Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju on Thursday, asking why the government was in a “great hurry” to amend the women’s quota law.

In his letter to Rijiju, Kharge also reiterated that an all-party meeting should be held on the matter after the current round of Assembly elections is completed in April.

Kharge’s letter came in response to one from the Union minister to the Congress chief

seeking a meeting with the party on plans to amend the Nari Vandan Adhiniyam, 2023, for its implementation.

“I have just received your letter on 26th March 2026. Opposition parties have already written to you on 24th March 2026, suggesting that an all-party meeting be held after April 29th, 2026, to discuss the implementation of the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam, 2023,” the Congress president said.

“I simply fail to understand why the government is in such

great hurry to further amend a Constitutional Amendment Act, 30 months after it was initially passed. We are all extremely busy with the election campaign. That is the reason why we had suggested that the meeting be held after the election campaign is over,” Kharge said.

This will, in no way, affect the implementation of the amended Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam, 2023, from the 2029 Lok Sabha election onwards, he said.

“In fact, on 21st September, 2023, during the debate in

the Rajya Sabha, I had myself demanded the immediate implementation of Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam, 2023, but the government had not agreed with my demand. I once again request you to convene an all-party meeting any time after April 29, 2026,” Kharge said.

Several Opposition parties on Tuesday wrote to the government, asking for an all-party meeting to be convened to discuss the modalities of the implementation of the women’s quota law.

MPPOST





Government of Haryana

Heartiest Greetings to all on the occasion of Ram Navami



“May the blessings of Prabhu Shri Ram always remain upon us and guide our paths towards righteousness and peace, illuminating our lives with wisdom and courage.”

- Narendra Modi

Information, Public Relations & Languages Department, Haryana

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ARAQCHI, QALIBAF WERE TAKEN OFF THE HIT LIST

Pakistan’s call saved Iranian leaders from Israel’s hit list, source says

ISLAMABAD: Israel removed Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araqchi and Parliamentary Speaker Mohammad Baqer Qalibaf from its hit list after Pakistan urged Washington to press Israel not to target them, a Pakistani source with knowledge of the discussions said on Thursday.

“The Israelis had their coordinates and wanted to take them out, we told the U.S. if they are also eliminated then there is no one else to talk to, hence the U.S. asked the Israelis to back off,” the source said. Pakistan’s military and foreign office did not immediately respond to requests for comment. Israel’s military declined to comment, and Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu’s office did not immediately respond to a request for comment.

The Wall Street Journal first reported that the two top Iranian officials had been temporarily removed from Israel’s list of officials to eliminate as they explore possible peace talks. The two officials have been removed from the list for up to four or five days, the Journal



Iran's foreign minister Abbas Araghchi was a marked man

said, citing U.S. officials, but did not mention any Pakistani role in it. Pakistan, Egypt, and Turkey are playing the role of mediator between Tehran and Washington to end the Iran war. Islamabad has maintained direct contact with both Washington and Tehran at a time when such channels are frozen for most other countries and has been actively involved in shuttle diplomacy. It has also

been seen as a likely venue if formal peace talks are held.

Iran is reviewing a 15-point proposal from U.S. President Donald Trump, sent through Pakistan, to end the war. The proposal calls for removing Iran’s stocks of highly enriched uranium, halting enrichment, curbing its ballistic missile program, and cutting off funding for regional allies, according to Israeli cabinet sources familiar with the plan. Trump has said Iran is desperate to make a deal, while Araqchi said Tehran was reviewing the U.S. proposal but had no intention of holding talks to wind down the conflict.

In Short

» The Wall Street Journal first reported that the two top Iranian officials had been temporarily removed from Israel’s list of officials to eliminate as they explore possible peace talks

» The two officials have been removed from the list for up to four or five days, the Journal said, citing U.S. officials, but did not mention any Pakistani role in it

yahu had authorized the military to target officials without prior authorization. Asked whether Araqchi and Qalibaf had been removed from an Israeli hit list following a request from Pakistan, Israeli military spokesman Nadav Shoshani said the military “has a rigorous process before every operation and every strike,” but added: “I’m not going to go into specific potential targets.”

Observers say Pakistan’s intervention highlights its strategic diplomatic leverage in the region, as well as the growing importance of neutral mediators in conflicts involving nuclear-capable nations. Analysts note that Iran’s insistence on preserving its nuclear program while seeking relief from economic sanctions may complicate negotiations but also underscores the high stakes of any potential agreement. Meanwhile, public opinion in the region appears increasingly vocal, with citizens of multiple countries expressing concern over foreign military interventions, pressuring states to pursue diplomatic avenues. AGENCIES

US ALLIES SEEK CLARITY FROM RUBIO ON IRAN OPERATIONS

G7 meets amid Ukraine, Iran wars & US uncertainty

VAUX-DE-CERNAY: Foreign ministers from the world’s leading Western democracies meet in France this week against the backdrop of wars in Iran and Ukraine, economic uncertainty, and mounting unease over an increasingly unpredictable U.S. foreign policy.

The two-day gathering at the restored 12th-century Abbaye des Vaux-de-Cernay, about 40 km (25 miles) southwest of Paris, brings together ministers from the G7 – Britain, Canada, France, Germany, Italy, Japan and the U.S. – alongside the European Union. The grouping, which first met as six in nearby Rambouillet 50 years ago, traditionally approached its core economic and geopolitical challenges with a broad consensus. That cohesion has frayed



Members meet during a bilateral meeting on Thursday

since Donald Trump returned to the U.S. presidency in 2025.

Allies and adversaries alike have spent the past year scrambling to respond to abrupt U.S. policy shifts, from tariffs to Ukraine, and now the Middle East conflict, which European diplomats and officials say lacks clear objectives or an exit strategy.

France’s army chief on Wednesday bemoaned Washington’s unpredictability, saying it was impacting allies’ interests and security.

“The U.S. attitude is an element of destabilisation of the international system for all players, not only for members of the G7, but also for China, (and) for many, many coun-

Trump administration frays G7 relationship

tries in the world,” said Thomas Gomart, director of the Paris-based French Institute of International Relations.

A top priority for Washington’s partners will be a debriefing from U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio, who will attend the meeting’s second day on Friday. Officials said allies are hoping to get greater clarity on the U.S. and Israeli military operations against Iran and on whether any meaningful diplomatic channel exists to end the conflict. AGENCIES

Trump defers China visit to May amid war

SEOUL: President Donald Trump will travel to China on May 14 and 15 for a rescheduled summit with his Chinese counterpart Xi Jinping, the White House has announced.

Trump, who was earlier scheduled to travel to Beijing by the end of this month, postponed his trip due to the war in Iran. Announcing Trump’s “long-awaited” trip to China, White House Press Secretary Karoline Leavitt said on Wednesday the US president and First Lady Melania will

also host President Xi and his wife, Peng Liyuan, for a reciprocal visit to Washington DC at a later date this year. “President Xi understood that it’s very important for the president to be here throughout the region right now. He understood, obviously, the request to postpone and accept it, which is why we have a meeting,” she said.

Asked if the war would conclude by the time of the meeting, Leavitt said. “We’ve always estimated approximately four to six weeks.” AGENCIES

As world watches Iran, Russia goes on spring offensive

KYIV: The Iran war has deflected global attention from Russia’s all-out invasion of its neighbour Ukraine as Europe’s biggest conflict since World War II enters its fifth year and an emboldened Kremlin undertakes a spring offensive.

The past week showed that neither side is easing up. Russia on Tuesday fired almost 1,000 drones and 34 missiles at Ukraine in one of the war’s biggest bombardments. The following day Ukraine launched almost 400 drones in the largest reported overnight attack on Russian regions and Crimea.

Ukraine’s fate is still Europe’s top foreign policy issue, fuelled by fears that Moscow has wider ambitions. Meanwhile, the Trump administration has wound down talks with Russian and Ukrainian delegations as the Iran war grips its attention. The administration has warned it could turn its back on the conflict if peace efforts come to nothing.

Only weeks ago, the Russian economy was starting to feel the pinch of sanctions. But Russia is now raking in billions of dollars from a temporary US waiver on



Fire and smoke raises after a Russian attack in Lviv, Ukraine

More than 15,000 Ukrainian civilians have been killed in war

oil sanctions against Moscow. The measure taken earlier this month aims to free up Russian oil cargo stranded at sea and ease supply shortages caused by the Middle East conflict.

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said the US move was “not the right decision” because it will further enable Russia’s military campaign. Fighting escalates

After a winter of relative calm on the front line, Russia is gearing up for the summer fighting season as fields dry out.

Russian forces are in an early phase of a spring offensive, assaulting Ukraine’s eastern so-called Fortress Belt of cities, said Elina Bektova of the Center for European Policy Analysis, a Washington-based think tank. “Over the past weeks, the Russians have intensified pressure on the battlefield and in the air,” she said. In Ukraine’s eastern Donbas region, Ukraine’s industrial heartland long coveted by Russian President Vladimir Putin, the situation is “critical,” she said, though Ukrainian troops say they are holding firm. AGENCIES

Lebanon’s turn? Israel plans to use Gaza tactics for ‘buffer zone’



An Israeli soldier jumps from a tank

BEIRUT: As Israel trades fire with Hezbollah, calls for mass evacuations and sends ground troops deeper into Lebanon, its leaders have hinted at a long-term occupation modelled on the devastating conquest of much of Gaza after Hamas’ October 7, 2023, attack.

Israel says it needs to establish a zone of control in the depopulated south to shield its own northern communities, which have faced daily rocket attacks since the Iran-backed militant Hezbollah group joined the wider war.

Many in Lebanon fear that could mean the open-ended displacement of over a million people, the flattening of their homes and a loss of territory.

Israel’s Defence Minister Israel Katz said this week that it would create a “security zone” up to the Litani River,

some 30 kilometres from the border in some places.

He said troops would destroy homes, which he claimed were being used by militants, and that residents would not return until northern Israel is safe.

The campaign would mirror the one in Gaza, in which Israeli forces flattened and largely depopulated the eastern half of the Palestinian territory, Katz said on Tuesday. Israel has said it won’t withdraw from the enclave until Hamas disarms as part of a US-brokered ceasefire deal. “We have ordered an acceleration in the destruction of Lebanese homes in contact-line villages to neutralise threats to Israeli communities, in accordance with the model of Beit Hanoun and Rafah in Gaza,” Katz said, referring to border towns that were largely obliterated. AGENCIES

Drone strike hits tanker in Black Sea, crew safere

ISTANBUL: A Turkish-operated oil tanker that had departed from Russia was struck by a naval drone on Thursday as it approached the Black Sea entrance to the Bosphorus Strait, Turkish officials said.

All 27 Turkish crew members of the Altura were unharmed in the attack, which occurred early Thursday and caused damage to the bridge and engine room.

Transport Minister Abdulkadir Uraloglu said the tanker was subjected to an “attack by an unmanned sea vessel,” without saying whether Ukraine was suspected to be behind the attack. AGENCIES

EU lawmakers approve trade deal with Washington but add safeguard

BRUSSELS: The European Parliament voted Thursday to approve a trade deal between Washington and Brussels but with amendments added to protect European interests should the United States fail to hold up its end of the bargain.

The deal was negotiated last July in Turnberry, Scotland, by US President Donald Trump and European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen. It set a 15 per cent tariff on most goods in an effort to stave off far higher import

Hungarian exports play a key role in fulfilling the energy needs of Ukraine

duties on both sides that might have sent shock waves through economies around the globe.

New language now says that the deal can be suspended if Washington “undermined the objectives of the deal, discriminated against EU economic operators, threatened member states’ territorial integrity, foreign and defence policies, or

engaged in economic coercion.”

That clause was forged because of the tensions over Greenland, said Bernd Lange, a German lawmaker and head of the EU’s parliamentary trade committee. Trump drew widespread condemnation across the 27-nation bloc by threatening to take control of Greenland. AGENCIES

Iran war leaves toxic time bomb ticking for future generations to come

‘War’s environmental toll could leave damage and health risks for decades’

QUEENSLAND: Oil depots spewing black smoke. Debris sinking in the Persian Gulf. Missiles pounding military sites. The Iran war has unleashed a toxic mix of chemicals, heavy metals and other pollutants that threaten everything from agriculture to drinking water to people’s health — and will leave behind environmental damage and health risks that could persist for decades, experts said.

“All the burning of oil and gas fields in the coastal areas, all the ships that are there, the oil tankers that are being burned or (sunk) — all of these mean pollution,” said Kaveh Madani, an Iranian scientist and director of the United Nations University Institute for Water, Environment and Health. “For someone like me who has fought for sustainability and protection of the environment in that region, this is like going many years backward.”

Documenting the damage has proved daunting, with a full accounting impos-



Plumes of smoke and fire rise after debris from an intercepted Iranian drone struck an oil facility, in Fujairah, the UAE

sible for now, said Doug Weir, director of the Conflict and Environment Observatory, a U.K.-based nonprofit that monitors environmental harms from armed conflicts. The group uses remote satellite sensing and open-source intelligence to identify damage and score environmental risks to people, ecosystems and agricultural land. So far, it has

recorded more than 400 environmentally concerning incidents related to the war, though much is still unknown due to delays in satellite imagery and an internet blackout in Iran, Weir said. Attacks on oil- and gas-related sites create some of the worst environmental risks because of impacts to air quality and soil and water pollution, as well as health threats

Summary

» The Iran war has unleashed a toxic mix of chemicals, heavy metals and other pollutants that threaten everything from agriculture to drinking water to people’s health

» Attacks on oil- and gas-related sites create some of the worst environmental risks because of impacts to air quality and soil

to people. Harder to quantify are risks from bombed military sites, some of which are deeply buried and some near populated areas, adding to “huge uncertainties” around potential impacts, Weir said.

Perhaps the most enduring images of the war are of darkened skies from oil infrastructure set ablaze by airstrikes, including two weeks ago when

black rain fell near Tehran, Iran’s capital.

Soot, ash and toxic chemicals from strikes on fuel depots and a refinery combined with water droplets in the atmosphere and fell back to Earth as an oily, acidic rain that prompted warnings to stay indoors. Microscopic soot raises risks of lung and heart problems, while toxic chemicals pose long-term cancer risks and heavy metals from the fallout could contaminate soil and water supplies, experts said. Debris and contamination from missiles, as well as potential strikes on manufacturing facilities also could unleash harmful pollution, experts said.

“If you hit an ammonia-producing plant for fertilizer or for food production... those release chemicals that are absolutely toxic,” said Mohammed Mahmoud, head of Middle East Climate and Water Policy with the United Nations University Institute of Water, Environment and Health. AGENCIES



EDITORIAL
CONFLICT
AND CLIMATE

War rarely confines itself to battlefields. It seeps into the air people breathe, the water they drink, and the soil that feeds them. The reported emergence of “black rain” over parts of Tehran, following coordinated strikes on oil facilities by the United States and Israel, is a stark illustration of this spillover. When fuel depots burn incompletely, they do not simply vanish into smoke; they release a cocktail of soot, carbon monoxide, nitrogen oxides, and other pollutants that linger in the atmosphere. When rain falls through this toxic haze, it becomes a carrier, pulling down the debris of war and redistributing it across land and water. The spectacle may appear unusual, even apocalyptic, but it is rooted in a grim scientific logic: conflict intensifies environmental damage in ways that are both immediate and enduring.

History offers uncomfortable precedents. The “black rain” that followed the atomic bombings of Hiroshima and Nagasaki in 1945 was one of the earliest documented cases of rainwater turning toxic due to suspended particles and radioactive debris. Decades later, during the Gulf War, burning oil wells in Kuwait turned the skies opaque and rainfall contaminated. Even outside direct conflict, large-scale environmental degradation—such as the biomass fires that darkened skies over São Paulo in 2019—has produced similar effects. These episodes reveal a pattern: when human activity releases vast quantities of pollutants into the atmosphere, rain becomes a mechanism of return. It gathers what we emit and delivers it back, often in more concentrated and harmful forms. Tehran’s experience is therefore not an anomaly but part of a recurring cycle in which industrial combustion and conflict converge to poison the environment.

The science behind black rain is neither mysterious nor reassuring. When oil and other fuels burn, they emit sulfur dioxide, nitrogen oxides, volatile organic compounds, and microscopic soot particles. These substances mix with moisture in the atmosphere, undergoing chemical reactions that produce sulfuric and nitric acids. Clouds effectively become laboratories of toxicity, and raindrops act as carriers, absorbing pollutants as they fall. In some cases, winds transport these contaminated clouds over long distances, spreading the impact far beyond the original site of combustion. Rain, in this sense, behaves less like a cleansing force and more like a delivery system, sweeping toxins from the sky and depositing them onto the Earth’s surface. What descends is not just water, but a diluted form of industrial and wartime waste.

The consequences of such rainfall extend deep into ecological systems. When acidic precipitation reaches the ground, it alters soil chemistry, stripping away essential nutrients such as calcium and magnesium while mobilising toxic metals like aluminium and mercury. This weakens plant life, disrupts microbial activity, and reduces agricultural productivity. Crops that depend on balanced soil conditions become vulnerable, and the long-term fertility of land is compromised. The damage does not stop at the surface. Polluted runoff carries these acids into rivers, lakes, and groundwater, lowering pH levels and threatening aquatic life. Many species cannot survive even slight changes in acidity, and their disappearance can trigger cascading effects throughout the food chain. What begins as a chemical reaction in the atmosphere can thus culminate in the degradation of entire ecosystems, altering landscapes in ways that are difficult to reverse.

Human health, inevitably, becomes part of this chain reaction. The same pollutants that form black rain also linger in the air as fine particulate matter, entering the lungs and bloodstream with every breath. Exposure can irritate airways, aggravate asthma, and increase the risk of chronic respiratory and cardiovascular conditions. The elderly, children, and those with pre-existing illnesses are especially vulnerable, but the risks extend to broader populations over time. Contaminated water and soil introduce another layer of danger, as heavy metals and toxins find their way into food systems and drinking supplies. Skin and eye irritation from direct exposure may be the most visible effects, but the more insidious damage lies in long-term health outcomes, including heightened risks of heart disease and certain cancers. In this way, the environmental fallout of conflict becomes a public health crisis, unfolding quietly but persistently.

What makes the events in Tehran particularly unsettling is not just the immediate damage, but the reminder they offer about the interconnectedness of war and environment. Modern conflicts are often assessed in terms of strategic gains or geopolitical shifts, yet their ecological costs are rarely accounted for with the same urgency. Black rain is a visible manifestation of these hidden costs—a signal that the consequences of war extend far beyond infrastructure and casualties. It underscores a broader truth: environmental systems do not recognise political boundaries, and the damage inflicted in one region can ripple outward in unpredictable ways. If there is a lesson to be drawn, it is that the price of conflict is not only measured in lives lost or territories contested, but also in the slow, often invisible degradation of the natural systems that sustain life itself.

RSS@100



ANIRBAN GANGULY

THE WRITER IS A MEMBER OF THE NATIONAL EXECUTIVE COMMITTEE (NEC), BJP, AND THE CHAIRMAN OF DR SYAMA PRASAD MOOKERJEE RESEARCH FOUNDATION

Guided by Doctorji’s emphasis on organisation over reaction, the idea of “one cohesive society” emerged as a long-term answer to fragmentation and instability

WORK EVOLUTION



JOHN FELIX RAJ & SOVIK MUKHERJEE

JOHN FELIX RAJ IS THE VICE CHANCELLOR, AND SOVIK MUKHERJEE IS AN ASSISTANT PROFESSOR OF ECONOMICS, BOTH AT ST. XAVIER’S UNIVERSITY, KOLKATA

Rather than replacing roles outright, AI integrates into workflows, accelerating routine tasks and expanding analytical capacity

One Cohesive Hindu Society

Dr Syama Prasad Mookerjee’s call for unity, shaped by Doctorji’s guidance, emphasised organisation over reaction as the foundation of enduring national strength

By April 1940, before he arrived in Nagpur, Dr Mookerjee had begun articulating his party’s—the Hindu Mahasabha’s—political creed, philosophy, and programme across the country, and emphasised the need for Hindu unity. His presidential address at the Barak Valley and Shillong Hill District Hindu Conference, held in Sylhet on 6 and 7 April 1940, was an important statement “on certain general questions of policy affecting the growth of the Hindu movement.”

It would be interesting to look at some of Dr Mookerjee’s statements, since there has been a sustained campaign of misinformation and vilification, distorting the Hindu Mahasabha’s and Dr Mookerjee’s political moves and decisions made around this time. “The Hindu Mahasabha stands primarily for the consolidation of the Hindus throughout India on a broad national basis,” Dr Mookerjee told the Barak Valley and Shillong Hill District Hindu Conference. “The word ‘Hindu’ is used in the widest sense possible, and includes every son and every daughter of India who regards this land as their fatherland and professes a religion of Indian origin. From this point of view, a Buddhist, a Jain, a Sikh are welcome to stand united under the banner of the Hindu Mahasabha for the common good of the country.”

Increasing cases of defilement of Hindu images were being reported from several districts of Bengal. Sirajganj sub-division of Pabna district in East Bengal, historian Anil Chandra Banerjee tells us, “earned special notoriety”, seeing 16 such cases occurring in a single month, in April 1939. Banerjee described the communal modus operandi: “Generally, the images were damaged and broken; sometimes they were garlanded with bones of cows. It appears from the reports of the District Magistrates and the Sub-Divisional Officers that these outrages were the result of ‘reckless and irresponsible speeches delivered by Muslim League leaders in huge gatherings attended by illiterates.’” Cases of atrocities on Hindu women were on the rise “in the villages where the Muslims live in an overwhelming majority.”



Rather than endorsing reactive or militarised responses, the focus remained on building a deeply rooted sense of collective identity

As he described the situation to Doctorji, Syama Prasad’s voice choked with emotion. “Organising a martial Hindu protection force in Bengal had become an urgent necessity; Hindus could not survive otherwise,” he argued. H.V. Seshadri records that, silently listening to him and knowing in depth the political and social texture of Bengal, Doctorji argued that it cannot be forgotten that “there is a Muslim government in Bengal” which will not “tolerate a Hindu militia”, and they also have the support of the British. For them, “the rise of Hindu power is a nightmare”; they will not tolerate an organisation of Hindus that Syama Prasad was planning.

On Syama Prasad’s query on the way forward, Doctorji laid out the roadmap. It was his well-thought-out and deeply reflected thesis. “Whether it is Punjab or Bengal or any other province,” he told Syama Prasad, “the chief cause of the pitiable plight of the Hindus is want of organisation among themselves,” and as long as this was not addressed, no solution was possible. “Hindus will continue to undergo such travails at one place or another,” and the “situation cannot be transformed by half-baked retaliatory measures. The Hindus must be made to feel intensely that they are one single cohesive society. The concept of one nationhood must be deeply engraved in their hearts. They must love one another and share the common goal of raising up our country. This is the only way, the only positive and enduring way of national resurrection.”

The Sangh was doing just that. It was working on that programme.

Doctorji had laid bare an actionable roadmap before Syama Prasad. Syama Prasad was moved and suggested that the Sangh “take part in politics.” Doctorji replied that the Sangh was “not interested in day-to-day politics,” but with “the support and blessings of enlightened people like” Syama Prasad, he had no doubt that the Sangh’s work in Bengal would grow fast, and the “protection and help needed by the Hindus will thus become automatically available.” Syama Babu, writes Seshadri, was “deeply impressed” with Doctorji’s confident and reassuring words, and “it was apparent that both had developed close rapport in their feelings and views.”

Soon, Dr Mookerjee wrote to Doctorji that he wished to start a training camp near Calcutta, similar to the one he had seen at Nagpur, from 18 June onwards. He expected more than a hundred trainees to take part and requested Doctorji to depute “a few experienced instructors who could impart physical, military and intellectual training” to the participants. While the arrangement was being made, Nana Palkar tells us in his biography of Doctorji that around a dozen swayamsevaks from Calcutta, who were in the Nagpur training camp, gathered to pay their respects to him. Doctorji, writes Nana Palkar, “having spent many years in Kolkata, was deeply concerned about the situation there.” He addressed the swayamsevaks from Bengal in Bengali. He emphasised

that pracharaks can be sent to Bengal, but “the real work will not be done just by sending pracharaks. The work must be done by people in that area itself. They must pull all their efforts towards this.”

While addressing the Faridpur Hindu Conference in the middle of June 1940, a report dated June 18, 1940, in the Hindustan Standard notes that Syama Prasad spoke of the need to organise a strong Hindu volunteer force and to take up immediately the “work of Hindu Sanghathan.” It echoed the words and direction he had received from Doctorji in Nagpur.

Speaking of the policy pursued by the Muslim League-dominated ministry in Bengal, Dr Mookerjee said that their policy made it imperative that the Hindus should fight for their rights with unabated vigour and strength. Mere passing of resolutions of protest would not meet the situation... the people should refuse to accept wrong and unjust decisions either in silence or in whispering protests.” The Hindus of Bengal, Dr Mookerjee “averged, had suffered because they had failed to unite and fight against deliberate wrongs done to them.” In these critical times, it was thus necessary “to shake off fear and mutual suspicion and resolutely combine for carrying on a struggle which would bring progress and freedom not only to themselves but to their province and country, which they had served in a spirit of sacrifice since the beginning of the freedom movement in India.”

The Faridpur Hindu Conference also urged the British Parliament to “make an immediate declaration that India will be recognised as an independent State immediately on the termination of the war, and that she would be free to frame her constitution.” It also called upon the British government to “take immediate steps for the nationalisation of the Army.” It also strongly condemned “the Pakistan scheme adumbrated by the Muslim League as anti-national and mischievous,” and called “upon all Hindus to resist the same.” Over the next few years, Syama Prasad succeeded in building up a formidable resistance to that idea and to its promoter, the Muslim League.

The intervening years leading to independence, partition, and the creation of West Bengal were momentous and challenging. Syama Prasad never forgot that larger message of the need to forge a greater Hindu unity in Bengal and across the country. As president of the All India Hindu Mahasabha, he strove to crystallise that unity. In Bengal, his relentless pursuit of that unity saw Hindu leaders, the intelligentsia, and the masses unite in raising the demand for the creation of West Bengal as a homeland for the Bengali Hindus—a homeland that would be forever integrated into the Indian Union.

About eleven years after his meeting with Doctorji, Syama Prasad had another historic meeting with Sri Guruji, by now Sarangchalak of the RSS, having succeeded Doctorji. That meeting led to the formation of the Bharatiya Jana Sangh in 1951. It was a party founded by Dr Mookerjee, with the aim of charting out a new politics for free India.

Speaking of patriotism, Sri Guruji once remarked, according to his biographer C.P. Bhishikar, that “selfless patriotism is the touchstone of the Sangh.” In his patriotism and uncompromising nationalism—especially when it came to the Hindus of Bengal, and after independence when it came to speaking up for India’s unity and integrity—Syama Prasad displayed that uncompromising and inspiring selflessness. In that, he truly reflected the spirit and ethos of a swayamsevak.

Views expressed are personal

Power Of AI Leverage

Fears of AI replacing jobs are misplaced; the real shift is subtler, reshaping work itself, rewarding those who use it, and exposing those who don’t

Every few months, a headline warns that artificial intelligence is about to erase millions of jobs. Writers worry about AI-generated articles; programmers’ eye code-completion tools; analysts wonder whether algorithms will soon own every data-driven decision. The anxiety is understandable—AI can write essays, generate images, crunch massive datasets, and mimic conversation with startling fluency.

But the reality inside most workplaces is less dramatic and more consequential. AI isn’t replacing people wholesale. It’s changing how the work gets done. The professionals pulling ahead aren’t the ones with the fanciest degrees; they’re the ones who’ve learned to use AI well.

The real threat, then, isn’t the model. It’s the colleague, competitor, or student who treats AI as a power tool. This isn’t humans versus machines. It’s humans with AI versus humans without it.

Technology and Human Adaptation

We’ve seen this movie before. When Gutenberg’s press spread in the fifteenth century, scribes feared obsolescence. During the Industrial Revolution, looms and steam engines were blamed for gutting craft trades. Later, computers triggered panic as they automated calculation and record-keeping.

Each wave followed the same arc: fear first, then a redefinition of work. The press didn’t kill writing; it expanded literacy and created new professions. Factories didn’t erase craftsmanship; they scaled production and spawned technical roles that hadn’t existed. Computers didn’t end analysis; they birthed software engineering, UX, and the digital economy.

AI is the latest turn of that wheel—with one twist. It reaches into cognitive work: drafting, researching, coding, analysing, designing. Google’s Gemini shines at research-heavy tasks and live information. Meta AI is tuned for quick, casual interactions woven into social platforms. OpenAI’s ChatGPT helps pro-



AI isn’t taking your job—the person who knows how to use AI might

professionals brainstorm, draft, and distil complex material in seconds. Developers lean on GitHub Copilot for suggestions and debugging; designers prototype with DALL-E before refining by hand. None of these erases expertise. They compress the grunt work so people can spend time on strategy, judgment, and creativity.

Rise of AI-Augmented Professional

A new archetype is emerging: the AI-augmented worker—not a replacement, but a partnership. The human sets direction; the model supplies speed, breadth, and a first draft of almost anything.

In marketing, tools like Jasper or ChatGPT let a team spin out a dozen ad variants in minutes, test tones, and iterate—rather than polishing a single draft all afternoon. In journalism, reporters feed thousands of documents into AI-assisted text analysis and surface patterns that once took weeks to spot. In academia, researchers use Elicit or Semantic Scholar’s AI features to triage literature reviews, summarise papers, and map gaps far faster than manual skimming.

The result isn’t fewer professionals. It’s professionals who can carry more weight, explore more options, and deliver sharper insights.

Productivity in the Age of Intelligent Tools

The productivity lift is hard to ignore. Work that used to take hours now collapses into minutes. An analyst who once cleaned spreadsheets, ran stats, and built charts by hand can now lean on Microsoft Copilot or AI-assisted Tableau to generate dashboards and call out insights almost instantly. Studies of coding assistants consistently show developers finishing tasks markedly faster than peers working without them.

Expectations shift with that speed. Teams assume quicker turnarounds and broader exploration. A gap opens—not because some people are smarter, but because some people have better leverage. Opportunity and Competition in an AI-Driven World

AI also flattens the playing field. Capabilities that once demanded specialists or expensive software are now in the hands of students, solo founders, and small teams. A founder can research a market, draft a pitch, mock up brand assets in Canva’s AI tools, and prototype a landing page without hiring a full crew. Students use Notion AI or Perplexity to organise notes, summarise readings, and generate study guides.

Access alone isn’t the edge, though. When everyone can open the same toolbox, the difference is how well you use it—creatively, strategically, consistently.

Human Edge in the AI Era

As AI settles into daily workflows, the skill stack is changing. Domain expertise still matters, but AI literacy is now table stakes: knowing what a model can do, how to prompt it, and where it trips. Verification is non-negotiable because models can be confidently wrong. Human judgment is the filter.

And some strengths remain stubbornly human: empathy, ethical reasoning, contextual nuance, original creativity. AI can flag anomalies in medical images; treatment still hinges on a clinician’s judgment and a conversation with a patient. It can draft a policy memo; leadership—weighing trade-offs, reading a room, taking responsibility—remains ours.

The pattern is clear: AI doesn’t erase the need for professionals; it redefines what makes a professional valuable. The advantage goes to those who pair human insight with machine efficiency.

Adaptation is the Real Competitive Advantage

AI is one of the defining technological shifts of our time, but the central challenge isn’t raw automation or job loss. It’s adaptation—how we rethink work, learning, and leverage.

Ignore the tools, and you risk falling behind, not for lack of talent, but because others can do more with the same hours. Embrace them and you expand what you’re capable of.

The future of work won’t belong to machines alone, or to humans alone. It will belong to humans who know how to collaborate with intelligent systems. Which is why one line keeps landing with such force: AI won’t replace you. But someone using it might.

Views expressed are personal

Infra projects see cost overrun of ₹5.66 lakh crore in February

‘As of Feb 2026, 1,948 ongoing infra projects, with total revised cost of Rs 41.98 lakh cr, are being monitored across 17 central ministries/depts’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Several infrastructure projects worth above Rs 150 crore each registered a cumulative cost overrun of Rs 5.66 lakh crore, according to a monthly government report for February 2026.

The latest ‘Flash Report on Central Sector Infrastructure Projects’ showed that the revised cost of all 1,948 projects, each valued at Rs 150 crore or higher, monitored by the statistics ministry stood at Rs 41,98,684 crore compared to their original cost of Rs 36,32,088 crore.

The report did not specify the actual number of projects that are facing cost overrun.

The Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI) stated, in a press release on Wednesday, that as of February 2026, 1,948 ongoing infrastructure projects, with a total revised cost of Rs 41.98 lakh crore, are being monitored across 17 central ministries/departments. The cumulative expenditure incurred on these projects stands at Rs 19.71 lakh crore, accounting for approximately 46.95 per cent of the revised project cost, indicating steady progress in project implementation.

A significant proportion of projects are at advanced stages, with 740 projects (38 per cent) achieving over 80 per cent physical progress, while 250 (13 per



The cumulative expenditure incurred on these projects stands at Rs 19.71 lakh crore, accounting for approximately 46.95% of the revised project cost

cent) have crossed 80 per cent financial completion. The data also reflects a balanced pipeline, with projects distributed across early and advanced stages of implementation. The Transport and Logistics sector accounts for the highest number of ongoing projects (1,421 projects), with revised estimates of Rs 22.96 lakh crore, underscoring the priority to connectivity-driven infrastructure growth.

The total 1,948 ongoing infrastructure projects include 793 Mega projects (project cost of Rs 1,000 crore and above) with an original cost of Rs 30.93 lakh crore, and 1,155 major projects (project cost

Highlights

- » A significant proportion of projects are at advanced stages, with 740 projects (38%) achieving over 80% physical progress
- » While 250 (13 per cent) have crossed 80 per cent financial completion
- » The Transport and Logistics sector accounts for the highest number of ongoing projects (1,421 projects), with revised estimates of Rs 22.96 lakh crore

below Rs 1,000 crore and up to Rs 150 crore), amounting to Rs 5.39 lakh crore. Physical and financial progress broadly move in tandem, with a large number of projects clustered at the initial (0–20 per cent) and advanced (81–100 per cent) stages, indicating a pipeline of newly-started projects alongside many nearing completions.

While physical progress exceeds financial progress in the 81–100 per cent range, financial progress is relatively higher in the early stages, reflecting upfront expenditure patterns in project implementation.

The Ministry of Road Transport & Highways accounts for

the highest number of projects, with 1,108 projects (56.88 per cent), and a share of total project cost of Rs 10.51 lakh crore (25.05 per cent), highlighting its central role in national infrastructure development.

The Ministry of Railways is implementing 245 projects (12.58 per cent), and also commands the largest share of total project cost at Rs 8.39 lakh crore (20 per cent).

The coal ministry accounts for implementing 128 projects (6.57 per cent), with a total project cost of Rs 2.41 lakh crore (5.88 per cent). The Ministry of Petroleum & Natural Gas, Ministry of Power, Ministry of Housing & Urban Affairs, and the Department of Water Resources, River Development & GR are implementing 113, 101, 55, and 49 projects, with associated costs of Rs 5.15 lakh crore, Rs 5.25 lakh crore, Rs 3.95 lakh crore, and Rs 2.25 lakh crore, respectively.

The remaining 149 projects (7.64 per cent), with a total cost of Rs 3.98 lakh crore (10 per cent), are distributed across various ministries/departments, including Higher Education, Civil Aviation, Steel, Telecommunications, Labour & Employment, Ports, Shipping & Waterways, Health & Family Welfare, Mines, DPIIT, and Sports.

Transport and Logistics remains the dominant sector, accounting for 55 per cent of

total revised project cost (Rs 22.96 lakh crore) across 1,421 projects (73 per cent of the total Projects), underscoring the central role of roads & highways, railways, aviation, urban public transport, shipping, and inland waterways in economic integration and logistics efficiency. The energy sector follows with 26 per cent of aggregated revised cost (Rs 10.95 lakh crore) across 220 projects, reflecting sustained emphasis on oil & gas infrastructure, electricity generation, transmission and distribution networks, and energy storage systems.

The communication infrastructure, with a project cost of Rs 2.74 lakh crore (7 per cent) across 14 projects, represents targeted interventions aimed at strengthening digital connectivity. Water & sanitation projects account for Rs 2.31 lakh crore (5 per cent) across 71 projects, highlighting continued focus on essential urban services.

The social and commercial infrastructure, comprising 74 projects with a revised project cost of Rs 0.79 lakh crore (2 per cent), reflects selective investments in education, healthcare, real estate, and tourism, hospitality and wellness. Projects classified under ‘Others’, amounting to Rs 2.22 lakh crore (5 per cent) across 148 projects, indicate diversification across sectors, such as coal, steel, metals, and mining.

DRIVES 92% OF TRANSACTIONS

UPI surpasses IMPS, debit cards as top payment mode among lenders

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: UPI has emerged as the dominant payment method among lenders, driving 91.89 per cent of transactions on the platform, far ahead of net banking, IMPS, and debit cards, a report said.

Female lenders deployed an average of Rs 2.5 lakh, more than four times higher than the average amount lent by men, according to the P2P Lending Trends Report 2025 released by LenDenClub, an RBI-registered peer-to-peer (P2P) lending platform.

The report, which analysed investment activity across more than one lakh lenders on the platform, said about 68 per cent of lenders on peer-to-peer (P2P) platforms lend across multiple borrowers to manage risk, indicating a clear shift towards more structured and disciplined lending behaviour.

As financial awareness improves and investors adopt disciplined diversification strategies, digital credit could become an increasingly meaningful component of modern investment portfolios, Bhavin Patel, Co-Founder and CEO of LenDenClub, said.

The average investment amount on the platform stands at around Rs 2 lakh, with investors typically allocating funds across a large number of borrowers, it said.

On average, it said, investors have funded over 200 borrowers, reflecting a clear preference for diversification to manage exposure. Nearly 68 per cent of investors have funded more than one loan,



In terms of tenure preference, majority of investors choose shorter durations of 2 to 6 months, as the platform was offering more short-term loans till last year

highlighting repeat participation and continued engagement on the platform.

In terms of tenure preference, majority of investors choose shorter durations of 2 to 6 months, as the platform was offering more short-term loans till last year, it said.

More than 95 per cent of the platform loans were of shorter duration for the period of data publishing.

The platform has recently introduced 12-month loan options, which are currently witnessing early demand as retail investors explore more predictable repayment cycles,

it said. Geographically, participation is expanding beyond major financial centres, it said, adding that the top five metro cities, Mumbai, Bengaluru, Pune, Hyderabad and Delhi, accounted for nearly 62 per cent of investor contribution on the platform.

“Digital infrastructure continues to play a key role in enabling participation. UPI remains the most preferred payment method, accounting for 92 per cent of all transactions on the platform. This is followed by IMPS at around 3 per cent, net banking at 3 per cent, and debit cards at 2 per cent,” it said.

The high share of UPI indicates the growing reliance on instant and convenient transacting systems for participating in lending activity, it said.

The report also noted that most lending transactions were initiated through mobile devices, indicating a clear shift toward real-time and on-the-go portfolio management among investors, it added.

Allianz Jio Reinsurance commences operations

NEW DELHI: Jio Financial Services Ltd (JFSL) and Allianz Group, through its wholly-owned subsidiary Allianz Europe BV, on Thursday announced that their reinsurance joint venture (JV) has commenced operations.

Allianz Jio Reinsurance Ltd is authorized to underwrite reinsurance in India with immediate effect following final regulatory approval from the Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI) on March 12, 2026.

Headquartered in Mumbai, Allianz Jio Re aims to become a strategic long-term partner for the Indian market with a mission to fortify the resilience of the country’s insurance ecosystem, the company said in a statement.

At a time when structural tailwinds are powering the sustainable growth of the sector — in line with the national mission of ‘Insurance for All’ by 2047 — the combination of JFSL’s local reach and digital infrastructure with Allianz’s robust underwriting and global reinsurance scale will empower insurers with the capacity and expertise needed to manage risk effectively, the statement said. PTI

Airlines facing big challenges, ‘hope we see better days’: DGCA

NEW DELHI: The Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) is trying to promote ease of doing business for airlines to help them grow and flourish as well as taking steps for passenger rights, its chief Faiz Ahmed Kidwai said.

There are big challenges for airlines, including taking longer routes and higher operational costs due to airspace curbs, he said, expressing hope that there would be “better days”.

“It is not only passenger rights which we are looking at... we are trying to ease things for the airlines also and the rules and regulations which are there, promote ease of doing business



because we want our airlines to grow and flourish,” Kidwai said.

He said many airlines have gone bust in India and emphasised the need to support carriers.

India is one of the world’s fastest-growing civil aviation markets and the DGCA as well as the government has been taking various initiatives.

Recently, it was decided that 60 per cent of seats in a domestic flight will be offered without any additional charges while the fare cap, imposed in the wake of IndiGo operational disruptions in December 2025, has been withdrawn. “We are facing a very typical time because, especially for our carriers, if you see the Pakistan airspace is closed for them,” he said.

Against the backdrop of West Asia conflict, airlines have to take longer routes, meaning carrying more fuel and the cost of fuel is going up. Also, carrying more fuel means less cargo and passengers so it hits revenues, he added. PTI

HFCL Limited unifies defence biz under new entity, loaded with ₹1,680 crore order book

NEW DELHI: Domestic technology firm HFCL Limited has consolidated its defence business under a new entity, HFCL Advance Systems Private Limited (HASPL), which will commence operations with a total order book of Rs 1,680 crore, the company said on Wednesday.

The company also announced its foray into aeronautics manufacturing with inorganic expansion to be executed through a newly acquired firm Spiral EHL Engineering Private Limited.

“HFCL will implement this consolidation through its subsidiary, HFCL Advance Systems Private Limited (HASPL),

which will act as the vehicle for multiple defence and aerospace business,” the company said in a statement.

HFCL said that the initiative brings together complementary capabilities across aerostructures, aeronautics, radar systems, and advanced thermal weapon sight solutions under one unified platform.

“One of the key highlights of the expansion is a confirmed export order book of approximately Rs 1,570 crore,” the statement said.

As part of this initiative, HASPL will acquire 100 per cent stake in an engineering and precision manufacturing company, Spiral EHL Engineer-

ing Limited (Spiral) which in turn will be acquiring the Aerostructure and Aeronautics business of Defsys Solutions Private Limited (Defsys) on a slump sale basis.

These steps will create a vertically integrated platform spanning design, prototyping, precision manufacturing, and system integration capabilities with HFCL Limited having majority equity, the statement said.

HFCL , Managing Director, Mahendra Nahata, said that the creation of HFCL Advanced Systems Private Limited represents HFCL’s most significant move with strategic commitment to building a sovereign,

NEW DELHI/MUMBAI: Indian airlines are set to operate a little over 23,000 weekly domestic flights during the summer schedule starting from March 29, which is 10 per cent less than the services flown during the same period a year ago.

Aviation watchdog DGCA has published the domestic flights summer schedule, which is from March 29 to October 24, for nine scheduled airlines.

A senior DGCA official on Thursday told PTI that the airlines would be operating around 10 per cent fewer flights in 2026 summer schedule compared to the previous

summer schedule.

During the 2025 summer schedule, there were 25,610 weekly flights and this time, a 10 per cent reduction would mean the number of services will come down by 2,561. Accordingly, the total count will be about 23,049 weekly flights, as per an analysis.

The Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) has put out the airline-wise domestic summer schedule for 2026 on its website but has not provided a consolidated figure and comparison with the previous summer schedule or the ongoing winter schedule.

The nine airlines that are to operate flights during the

2026 summer schedule are Air India, Air India Express, IndiGo, Akasa Air, SpiceJet, Alliance Air, FLY91, Star Air and IndiaOne Air.

In the current winter schedule from October 26, 2025, to March 28, 2026, airlines were to operate 26,495 weekly flights. However, the massive operational disruptions at IndiGo in early December had an impact and the DGCA had curtailed the carrier’s winter schedule flights by 10 per cent.

Meanwhile, the ongoing West Asia conflict, involving the US, Israel and Iran that started on February 28, is significantly disrupting flight services of Indian carriers to the

region.

Against this backdrop, airline executives told PTI that there is a lot of uncertainty and there could be further reduction in the existing summer schedule itself.

The schedule was mostly prepared in January and February, a period during which there were no risks related to the Middle East conflict, which started on February 28. Now, the scenario is completely different and operational complexities have increased, one of the officials said.

On March 24, IndiGo said it intends to start its domestic summer schedule with nearly 2,000 daily flights in April. PTI

OECD forecasts India’s GDP to grow at 7.6% in FY26, 6.1% in FY27

NEW DELHI: The Organisation for Economic Cooperation and Development (OECD) on Thursday projected India’s GDP to grow at 7.6 per cent in FY26 and 6.1 per cent in FY27. The OECD in its interim Economic Outlook report said the evolving conflict in the Middle East has “human and economic costs” for the countries directly involved, and will test the resilience of the global economy.

A halt in shipments through the Strait of Hormuz and the closure or damage of energy infrastructure has generated a surge in energy prices and disrupted the global supply of energy and other important commodities, such as fertilisers.

“The decline in (US) tariffs should support growth in India, though gas rationing will disrupt some production activities and fiscal support is expected to fade, with growth easing from 7.6 per cent in fiscal year FY26 to 6.1 per cent in FY27 and 6.4 per cent in FY28,” the OECD said.

The fading deflationary impact of past food and energy price-reducing shocks will be exacerbated by the recent surge in global energy prices, OECD said, which will push inflation up from 2 per cent in FY26 to 5.1 per cent and 4.1 per cent in FY27 and FY28, respectively.

Amongst the emerging-market economies, India is

projected to raise policy rates temporarily in the second quarter of 2026 to help offset stronger inflationary pressures, the OECD report said.

US bilateral tariff rates have declined following the US Supreme Court ruling against the tariffs imposed under the International Emergency Economic Powers Act. There are particularly large reductions for several emerging-market economies, including India. Nonetheless, the overall US effective tariff rate remains well above that prevailing prior to 2025.

The OECD report projected global GDP growth to ease to 2.9 per cent in 2026 before edging up to 3 per cent in 2027. PTI

Fertiliser production to dip 10-15% if Middle East issues persist

‘The ongoing issues in the Middle East could disrupt fertiliser supply chain at a crucial time for the kharif season’

MUMBAI: India’s annual domestic output of urea and complex fertilisers is likely to decline by 10-15 per cent due to supply chain disruptions caused by the ongoing conflict in the Middle East, a Crisil Ratings report said on Thursday.

“The ongoing issues in the Middle East could disrupt the fertiliser supply chain at a crucial time for the kharif season. Disruption in LNG and ammonia supplies continuing for about three months could cut domestic urea and complex fertiliser production by 10-15 per cent,” Crisil Ratings Director Anand Kulkarni said. However,

he said the impact on production will be cushioned to some extent by the recent government directive allocating 70 per cent of gas to urea manufacturers.

He added that the fertiliser inventory of around three months, along with expected imports from alternative sources, will mitigate the risk of immediate supply shortages.

Further, Crisil Ratings said the increase in prices of raw materials and imported fertilisers is likely to increase working capital requirements of players and also raise the subsidy bill of the government by Rs 20,000-25,000 crore.

CLOSER LOOK

- » ‘Impact on output will be cushioned to some extent by recent govt directive allocating 70% gas to urea makers’
- » ‘The fertiliser inventory of around three months, along with expected imports from alternative sources, will mitigate the risk of immediate supply shortages’

Urea accounts for 45 per cent of fertiliser consumption in India, complex fertilisers (diammonium phosphate, or DAP, and nitrogen, phosphorus and potassium, or NPK) for one-third, and single super phosphate (SSP) and muriate of potash (MOP) for the rest.

Fertiliser sector dependence on imports remains high, with 20 per cent of urea and one-third of complex fertilisers, primarily DAP, being imported.

The key raw materials for urea (natural gas, which comprises 80 per cent of the raw material cost) and com-

plex fertilisers (ammonia and phosphoric acid) are largely imported due to limited domestic reserves. For both urea and DAP imports, the Middle East remains an important region, accounting for 40 per cent of imports in April-Dec FY26.

For domestic fertiliser production, the dependence on the Middle East is even higher, with 60-65 per cent of LNG and 75-80 per cent of ammonia imports coming from the region, it added. Crisil Ratings said the reduced capacity utilisation is likely to dent profitability, with urea manufacturers likely to see a larger impact as

sub-optimal capacity utilisation will reduce energy efficiency.

The industry will require additional subsidy support from the government to mitigate the impact, the report added.

Given the strategic importance of the sector, the government has supported it in the past through increased Nutrient-Based Subsidy rates & additional subsidy for DAP players. “Factoring in the elevated input costs and imported fertiliser prices for a quarter, the overall subsidy budget is likely to increase by 12-15 per cent from initial estimates of Rs 1.71 lakh crore for FY27. PTI

JSW Motors partners with Dassault for digital drive

MUMBAI: JSW Motors on Thursday said it will use French firm Dassault Systèmes’ platform as its core digital backbone for the upcoming New Energy Vehicles (NEVs) as part of a collaboration.

The partnership is aimed at advancing the localization of the company’s product development capabilities through the deployment of Dassault’s 3DX platform, a statement said. In parallel, JSW Motors said it is implementing a manufacturing execution system on the same platform, enabling seamless

digital continuity and end-to-end traceability.

“We are building a technology-led future mobility ecosystem which is engineered in India. We have partnered with Dassault Systèmes to embed its digital platform across the vehicle lifecycle, from design to manufacturing at JSW Motors,” said Ranjan Nayak, CEO, JSW Motors.

The company, he said, is also in “advanced discussions” with several additional domestic suppliers to further deepen localization and strengthen India’s automotive supply chain, he added. PTI

‘Conflict in West Asia likely to hit Asia-Pacific growth, fuel inflation’

‘The conflict affects economies in Asia & Pacific through higher energy prices, supply chain & trade disruptions & tighter financial conditions’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The West Asia conflict could lower economic growth in Asia Pacific region by up to 1.3 percentage points over 2026-2027 and raise inflation by 3.2 percentage points if energy market disruptions last more than a year, according to a research by the Asian Development Bank (ADB).

“The conflict affects economies in Asia and the Pacific through higher energy prices, supply chain and trade disruptions, and tighter financial conditions. Tourism and remittances could also be impacted,” ADB said in the report.

The report outlines three risk scenarios indicating that effects on the region's developing economies will depend largely on the duration of disruptions, it said.

Under a short-lived conflict, energy price pressures would ease relatively quickly. More prolonged disruptions would lead to larger and more persistent impacts on growth and inflation, it said.

Adverse effects on growth will be most severe for economies in developing South-east Asia and the Pacific, with



‘The ADB report outlines three risk scenarios indicating that effects on the region’s developing economies will depend largely on the duration of disruptions’

inflation rising highest in South Asian economies, it said, adding, the scenarios reflect the high degree of uncertainty around how the conflict and the associated disruptions will evolve, and should be treated with caution.

In addition to higher energy prices, they account for broader supply chain disruptions and a global tightening of financial

Highlights

- » Under a short-lived conflict, energy price pressures would ease relatively quickly
- » More prolonged disruptions would lead to larger and more persistent impacts on growth and inflation, the report said
- » Adverse effects on growth will be most severe for economies in developing Southeast Asia and the Pacific, with inflation rising highest in South Asian economies, it said

conditions, it said.

“Prolonged energy disruptions could force economies in developing Asia and the Pacific to navigate a difficult trade-off between weaker growth and higher inflation. Governments should focus on containing market stress and protecting the most vulnerable, while adopting policies to improve longer-term resilience,” ADB Chief

Economist Albert Park said.

The report suggested policies should focus on stabilization rather than suppression of price signals. Allowing higher energy prices to pass through, at least in part, can encourage energy conservation, fuel switching, and investment in alternative energy sources.

Broad price controls or generalized subsidies risk distorting incentives, delaying adjustment, and misallocating resources, it said.

With regard to fiscal support, it said, it should be targeted and time-bound and priority should be given to supporting vulnerable households and the most affected industries.

Well-targeted measures can cushion the social impact of higher prices while containing fiscal costs and preserving incentives to adjust to the shock, it said.

Besides, it said, central banks should focus on limiting excessive market volatility while keeping a close watch on inflation expectations.

“The priority should be to provide targeted liquidity support to preserve orderly market functioning. Tightening policy

too aggressively risks amplifying growth headwinds and exacerbating financial volatility. While some tightening may be warranted, anchoring inflation expectations with effective central bank communication will remain key,” it said.

Governments should curb energy demand where feasible, it said, adding, practical measures include temperature mandates to limit air-conditioning, cuts to non-essential lighting, peak-hour electricity-saving campaigns, and work-from-home or staggered schedules.

Incantivizing public transport use and car-free days in urban areas on public holidays can also help reduce transport fuel use, it added.

ADB is a leading multilateral development bank supporting sustainable, inclusive, and resilient growth across Asia and the Pacific.

Working with its members and partners to solve complex challenges together, ADB harnesses innovative financial tools and strategic partnerships to transform lives, build quality infrastructure, and safeguard our planet. Founded in 1966, ADB is owned by 69 members—50 from the region.

‘West Asia conflict to strain India’s FY2027 fiscal math’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A surge in global crude oil and natural gas prices amid the West Asia conflict is likely to complicate India's fiscal position in FY2027, potentially increasing subsidy burdens and pressuring revenues, ratings agency ICRA said.

Crude prices have more than doubled from pre-crisis levels, raising input and logistics costs and disrupting supplies, including key fertiliser inputs, the agency said. This could lift the government's fertiliser and LPG subsidy outgo while weighing on corporate tax collections, refining margins and dividend receipts.

ICRA said the government may use the Economic Stabilisation Fund to absorb part of the fiscal shock, along with measures such as front-loading subsidy payments and seeking supplementary grants later in the year.

While these buffers could help limit any major slippage from the fiscal deficit target of 4.5 per cent of GDP, risks remain skewed to the upside if elevated energy prices persist due to a prolonged conflict, it added.

“Amid the ongoing geopolitical conflict in the West Asia region, global crude oil and natural gas prices have surged and displayed considerable volatility owing to supply and logistical disruptions in the region, with the former more than doubling

Crude prices have more than doubled from pre-crisis levels, raising input and logistics costs and disrupting supplies, including key fertiliser inputs, ICRA said

compared to pre-crisis levels.

“This complicates the Government of India's (GoI) budget math for FY2027, vide a potential rise in the fertiliser and fuel subsidy burden, lower excise collections in the event of a cut in excise duty to compensate Oil Marketing Companies (OMCs) for marketing losses and an adverse impact on corporate tax revenues,” it said.

ICRA believes that the Economic Stabilisation Fund (ESF) could be utilised to absorb a portion of the aforesaid revenue/expenditure shock to the GoI's fiscal situation.

Besides, the GoI can front-load subsidy pay-outs in H1 FY2027 and announce supplementary demand for grants (SDG) later, if needed, that could be partly absorbed by the typical expenditure savings seen in recent years.

These buffers may prevent a large overshooting in the government's fiscal deficit target of 4.5 per cent of GDP (based

on the 2022-23 GDP series), although sizeable upside risks could emerge if the ongoing conflict persists for a prolonged period, keeping crude oil and natural gas prices elevated, beyond our current baseline forecasts.

ICRA said the West Asia conflict has pushed up the international prices of crude oil (\$157 per barrel and \$104 per barrel for Indian basket and Brent, respectively, on March 23) and liquefied natural gas (\$22 per million British thermal unit) to elevated levels, while also disrupting supplies, including those of key inputs for fertiliser production.

“This may have direct implications for the fertiliser and petroleum industries, including the surge in input and logistical costs, reducing refining margins of downstream players, albeit augur well for upstream oil companies,” ICRA said.

Besides, ICRA expects modest upside to small savings collections in FY2026 over the revised estimate (RE), which can be carried forward to FY2027, along with the typical expenditure savings of Rs 1.8 trillion/annum on average seen during FY2019-2025 would provide some buffer.

If the conflict keeps the energy prices elevated for a prolonged period, it would pose upside risks to the central government's FY2027 fiscal deficit target of 4.5 per cent of GDP (as per 2022-23 GDP series).

Fuel-thirsty Asian nations line up for Russian oil

MOSCOW: Asian countries including Vietnam, Thailand, the Philippines, Indonesia and Sri Lanka are lining up to buy Russian oil as the Iran war blocks supplies, raising the possibility that demand may exceed supply, several sources including Russia said.

Since the war in Ukraine prompted European customers - once the biggest buyers of Russian oil and gas - to shun Moscow, India and China have accounted for around 80 per cent of Russian oil exports. Turkey has also been a significant buyer, Reuters reported.

But in recent weeks, a host of Asian countries have been lining up, according to various sources including media and Russia.

“Demand is high, particularly for alternative destinations. As a result, a point may come when it becomes difficult to meet additional demand,” Kremlin spokesman Dmitry Peskov said in response to a question about Russian oil demand. A fifth of global oil production has effectively been blocked from reaching the market due to the US-Israeli war on Iran which has halted traffic through the Strait of Hormuz.

Russia has benefited from high oil prices and a 30-day sanctions waiver from the United States for purchases of Russian oil at sea.

Oil revenues and natural gas sales generate around a quarter of the country's state funds. AGENCIES

Health insurance sector grows at 9%, premiums top ₹1.2L cr in FY25

NEW DELHI: India's health insurance sector continues to witness robust growth, growing at a rate of around 9 per cent, with total health insurance premiums volume exceeding Rs 1.2 lakh crore in FY25. This growth reflects increasing awareness, improved access to healthcare financing, and a rising demand for financial protection against medical expenses, a finance ministry statement said.

In order to enhance efficiency and ensure timely support to policyholders, the Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (Irdai) has prescribed specific timelines for the processing of cashless health insurance claims, it said.

Time limit has been prescribed for cashless settlement including cashless pre-authorisation has to be approved within one hour and final authorisation within three hours.



These timelines are aimed at minimising delays and ensuring that patients receive timely access to medical care, it said.

There has been increase in health insurance premiums driven by factors such as ageing policyholders, higher coverage, enhanced features, among others, it said.

Irdai's 2024 regulations specify that insurance products are priced fairly, based on all relevant risk factors, and remain viable and value-driven, with periodic review by the appointed actuary using credible data and customer feedback, it said.

Further, as per Bima Bhara portal of Irdai, it said, during 2024-25, 1,37,361 general and health insurance grievances were reported, of which 1,27,755 (93 per cent) were disposed of during the year itself.

Instances of claims disallowance or repudiation are largely attributable to specific policy conditions and limitations, it said.

Some of the reasons for claims disallowance or repudiation include exceeding sum insured, co-payment clause, sub-limits in policies, deductible in top-up policies, room rent capping, proportionate charges, non-medical expenses, etc, it said.

Additionally, it said, several measures have been taken by Irdai to enhance clarity, streamline claims processing, and strengthen policyholder trust. PFI

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Reliance Industries says hasn't bought Iranian oil since US's temporarily removal of sanctions

NEW DELHI: Reliance Industries on Thursday said it has not bought crude oil of Iranian origin since the US temporarily removed sanctions to ease pressure on prices that followed the US-Israeli war on Iran.

In a statement, Reliance termed reports of it buying Iranian oil as baseless and incorrect.

It said it “categorically rejects recent media reports that the company has purchased crude oil of Iranian origin.”

The government earlier this week said resuming the buying of Iranian oil will be based on techno-commercial feasibility.

Historically, India was a major buyer of Iranian crude, importing significant volumes of Iranian Light and Heavy grades due to strong refinery compatibility and favourable



commercial terms.

Following sanctions tightening in 2018, imports ceased from May 2019, with volumes replaced by Middle Eastern, US and other grades.

At peak, Iranian crude accounted for 11.5 per cent of India's total imports.

Last weekend, the US waived sanctions on the purchase of Iranian oil at sea for 30 days in its latest attempt to ease oil prices that have been driven up by the US-Israeli war

Historically, India was a major buyer of Iranian crude due to strong refinery compatibility and favourable commercial terms

on Iran.

An estimated 140 million barrels of Iranian oil are on vessels at sea.

While the waiver allowed countries to purchase those barrels, it is unclear how payments will be made.

Iran remains cut off from SWIFT (Society for Worldwide Interbank Financial Telecommunication) - a global messaging network used by banks and financial institutions to securely send and

receive information about financial transactions.

Industry sources said the last purchases from Iran were made in Euros using a Turkish bank as a go-between, but that option no longer exists.

Iran was cut off from the SWIFT system in March 2012 following European Union sanctions over its nuclear programme, with the move forcing the disconnection of multiple Iranian banks and severely restricting global financial transactions.

Further disruptions occurred in 2018, after the United States reimposed sanctions, leading to renewed suspension of several Iranian banks from the network, which significantly constrained Tehran's ability to conduct international trade, receive oil payments and access foreign currency reserves. PFI

WTO’s dysfunctional dispute settlement system deprives countries of effective redressal: Goyal

NEW DELHI: India on Thursday called upon WTO members to work towards making the WTO's dispute settlement system fully functional, as the current dysfunctional mechanism has deprived countries of receiving effective redressal.

On the first day of the World Trade Organisation's (WTO) 14th ministerial conference (MC14) in Yaounde, Cameroon, Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal said that there is a need for a careful reconsideration of the further extension of the moratorium on customs duties on e-commerce trade.

“A dysfunctional Dispute Settlement System has deprived Members from effective redressal. We must restore

the automatic and binding dispute settlement system,” he said.

Since 2009, the WTO's dispute settlement mechanism has not been functioning properly as the US has stalled appointments of Members in the Appellate Body.

The World Trade Organisation (WTO) Members have agreed not to impose customs duties on electronic transmissions since 1998, and the moratorium has been periodically extended at successive ministerial conferences (MC), which is the highest decision-making body of the 166-member body.

India has time and again emphasised the need to discuss the scope of the duty moratorium as there are revenue impli-

cations because of it.

The four-day MC14 will end on March 29.

“In the absence of a common understanding among Members on the scope of the moratorium on customs duties on electronic transmissions and given its potentially significant implications, the continued extension of this moratorium warrants careful reconsideration,” he said.

On WTO reforms, the minister said the necessary reform should be carried out through a transparent, inclusive and member-driven process, keeping development at its core, upholding the foundational principles such as non-discrimination, consensus-based decision-making and equity.

A key principle of special and differential treatment (S&DT) should be precise, effective and operational, he added.

On agriculture, he said permanent solution on public stockholding for food security purposes, special safeguard mechanism and cotton are long-pending mandated issues and the member countries “must deliver on them on priority.”

“India remains committed to negotiating a comprehensive Fisheries Subsidies Agreement that balances current and future fishing needs, protects the livelihoods of poor fishers, with appropriate and effective S&DT,” Goyal said. PFI

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NEW DELHI: Jio Platforms is likely to file its Draft Red Herring Prospectus (DRHP) with Sebi in the coming few days, setting the stage for what could be India's largest-ever IPO.

The offering will be structured as an offer for sale (OFS), with several existing foreign investors preparing to pare their stakes, sources said.

In separate notes last year, Jefferies had estimated Jio's valuation at \$180 billion, while JP Morgan had pegged the valuation of Jio Platforms - the entity that houses Reliance Industries' telecom and digital businesses at \$136 billion.

DRHP could be filed as early as March-end, and discussions



are on with over a dozen foreign investors to pare part of their stakes in the upcoming public issue. The IPO - touted to be India's largest ever public offer - will be an OFS, they said.

Jio Platforms' stock market listing is expected to take place in the first half of 2026. At the annual shareholder meeting in August last year, RIL Chairman Mukesh Ambani had said: “I

am sure that it will be a very attractive opportunity for all investors,” and had promised that Jio's plans for the future are “even more ambitious.”

Earlier, Jio Platforms had raised about Rs 1,52,056 crore from over a dozen high-profile investors, namely Facebook, Google, Silver Lake, Vista Equity Partners, General Atlantic, KKR, Mubadala, ADIA, TPG, L Catterton, Public Investment Fund of Saudi Arabia, Intel Capital and Qualcomm Ventures, for a total consideration of 32.9 per cent stake.

Facebook (now Meta) holds a 10 per cent stake in Jio Platforms, while Google has another 7.7 per cent. PFI

India’s tablet PC mkt up 2% YoY, with Samsung leading the chart, Apple supplies drop 2%

Samsung’s tablet PC supplies in India market grew by 15% y-o-y which led to company clocking 31% market share in 2025 against 27% it registered in 2024

NEW DELHI: India tablet PC market grew by 2 per cent year-on-year in 2025 with Samsung leading the supplies in the segment while Apple and Acer recording dip in shipments, a Counterpoint Research report said on Thursday.

Counterpoint Research, principal analyst, Anshika Jain, said that India's tablet market saw a clear shift towards premiumisation, driven by strategic product refreshes across key brands.

“The Rs 30,000-Rs 40,000 price band emerged as the fastest-growing segment, with

shipments rising nearly 7 times, reflecting increasing consumer preference for higher-performance devices,” Jain said.

Samsung's tablet PC supplies in India market grew by 15 per cent year-over-year which led to the company clocking 31 per cent market share in 2025 compared to 27 per cent it registered in 2024.

“Samsung retained its market leadership in 2025, anchored by the Galaxy Tab A9 series across the first three quarters before transitioning to the successor A11 series in Q4 2025, reinforcing its stronghold

in the Rs 15,000-Rs 30,000 segment while sustaining its premium presence through the Galaxy Tab S portfolio,” the report said.

Apple followed Samsung with 20 per cent share in 2025 despite a decline of 2 per cent on YoY basis.

“Apple ranked second, with the iPad (2025) 128GB Wi-Fi variant emerging as a key driver in the Rs 30,000-Rs 40,000 band, significantly influencing the market's premium mix in H2 2025. The iPad Pro series further accelerated OLED penetration, strengthening Apple's

CLOSER LOOK

» Apple followed Samsung with 20 per cent share in 2025 despite a decline of 2 per cent on YoY basis

» ‘Apple at 2nd spot, with iPad (2025) 128GB Wi-Fi variant emerging as key driver in Rs 30K-Rs 40K band, influencing market’s premium mix in H2 2025’

» Lenovo clocked 15% market share with 24% growth in supplies, Xiaomi 11% with 74% jump in shipments while Acer supplies declined by 50% leading to market share plummeting to 10% in 2025 from 21% in 2024

positioning in the high-performance segment,” the report said.

Lenovo clocked 15 per cent market share with 24 per cent growth in supplies, Xiaomi 11

per cent with 74 per cent jump in shipments while Acer supplies declined by 50 per cent leading to market share plummeting to 10 per cent in 2025 from 21 per cent in 2024. 2025 also marked a turning point for India's tablet manufacturing landscape, the report said.

“Exports crossed one million units from negligible levels in prior years, led by Samsung and Lenovo, with shipments directed toward the US and key European markets. At the same time, domestic production accounted for 50 per cent of annual shipments reflecting

accelerated localization. This dual momentum positions India not just as a growing consumption market, but increasingly as a strategic manufacturing base within the global tablet supply chain,” it said.

Counterpoint expects that the Indian tablet market is expected to see robust growth in 2026, supported by the strong momentum witnessed in the fourth quarter of 2025.

“While memory pricing will remain, a dynamic factor influencing device costs and margins, sustained demand for higher configurations and pro-

ductivity-oriented devices is likely to support value growth. The export market will be particularly important to look out for in 2026, as increasing localization and supply chain diversification position India as a growing manufacturing hub beyond domestic demand,” the report said.

According to the market research firm, the evolution of AI-enabled tablets and on-device AI features is expected to gradually enhance user experiences, laying the foundation for the next phase of market expansion. PFI

New blood, big hits?

Fresh faces are ready to light up IPL this season

NEW DELHI: Vaibhav Sooryavanshi and Ayush Mhatre hogged the limelight in their debut IPL season last year and in the upcoming edition too, there would be quite a few who would like to justify the tournament tagline of “Where Talent Meets Opportunity”.

We take a look at some of the new faces who are expected to make a name for themselves in the next eight weeks.

The list comprises both Indian and international names who either haven't yet made their IPL debut or have played less than five games so far.

Prashant Veer (CSK)

There are plenty of cricketers in India, who bowl slow left-arm orthodox and bat left-handed. But none of them are faced with the task of filling up the big boots of Ravindra Jadeja like the 20-year-old Amethi-born Prashant Veer.

Never before has one witnessed Chennai Super Kings invest so heavily in youth.

The franchise bagged him with a Rs 14.20 crore bid, based more on potential and how the scouts felt after looking at him during trials.

The 20-year-old has only nine Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy (SMAT) matches under his belt but with a bowling economy rate of 6.45 and a



RCB's Jacob Bethell during a practice session on Thursday

PTI

batting strike-rate of 167 plus, Prashant Veer is expected to play a big part.

Auqib Nabi (DC)

At 29, Nabi isn't a spring chicken and has a good eight years of domestic cricket under his belt but the anticipation surrounding his IPL debut would make DC fans believe that they are in for something special.

After a stellar Ranji sea-

son during which he claimed 60 odd wickets to singlehandedly get the trophy for Jammu and Kashmir, the 'Baramullah Express's big-match temperament and India prospects will be judged this year. He has played 34 T20 games for J&K in SMAT and the economy rate of 7.74 is good for someone who mostly bowls in Powerplays.

Ashok Sharma (GT)

Ashok, one of the fastest

Second phase of the IPL from April 13-May 24

NEW DELHI: The second phase of the IPL 2026 will begin on April 13 and conclude on May 24, the BCCI announced on Thursday while releasing the full fixtures of the league phase.

The first phase runs from March 28 to April 12, with defending champions Royal Challengers Bengaluru and Sunrisers Hyderabad facing off in the league opener at the M Chinnaswamy Stadium on Saturday. The final is slated for May 31 in Bengaluru. “The remainder of the league stage, comprising 50 matches, will be played from April 13 to May 24, 2026, across 12 venues in India,” BCCI secretary Devajit Saikia said. “Matches will be held in Bengaluru, Mumbai, Chennai, Kolkata, Delhi, Ahmedabad, Hyderabad, Lucknow, Jaipur, Dharamshala.” AGENCIES

young bowlers in India, has been a part of Rajasthan Royals set-up but hasn't got a game so far in the IPL.

There are no guarantees that the 23-year-old will get one this season with GT, especially with Mohammed Siraj and Prasidh Krishna being around as first two choices along with Kagiso Rabada.

Tejasvi Dahiya (KKR)

Kolkata Knight Riders head coach Abhishek Nayar's protegee Angkrish Raghuvanshi is being prepared as the batter-keeper since he has already played a couple of IPL seasons.

But the 23-year-old Dahiya, who hails from Delhi, is also

a serious talent, who if persisted with, could give results in long run. He scored a half-century for Delhi during the last SMAT and a strike-rate of 168 makes him a good bet in the middle-order.

Jacob Bethell (RCB)

The 22-year-old scored a half-century last season in one of the two games that he got a look-in but this time, Bethell is coming into the IPL on the back of a superb century in the T20 World Cup semi-final against India at the Wankhede.

On Chinnaswamy belters, he along with Jitesh Sharma, could become a nightmare for the opposition teams. AGENCIES

'TAKES THE SKILL OUT OF THE GAME'

‘Nothing to Prove’: Gill ahead of IPL; slams Impact Sub rule

AHMEDABAD: Shubman Gill on Thursday said he has nothing to prove in the upcoming IPL after being dropped from the Indian team leading into the 2026 T20 World Cup.

Gill was the India vice-captain in the shortest format but was dropped to accommodate Sanju Samson in the top-order. India went on to win a record third title.

Gill captains the Indian Test and ODI teams besides leading Gujarat Titans in the IPL.

“Not at all, sir. I think if you look at the past three or four seasons, I think I have the most runs in IPL. So I don't think I don't have anything to prove in this season particularly.”

“And the four years that I've played for this team, I think we have done decently well as a team. And I think I've done decently well as a batsman. So I don't think I need to prove to anyone, my worth,” said Gill in the pre-season conference here when asked if he had a point to prove after the World Cup snub.

Gill on Wednesday became the latest Indian cricketer to criticise the Impact Player rule in the IPL, saying “it takes the skill out of the game”.

The other Indian players who have expressed their concerns over the rule include



Shubman Gill amassed 650 runs last season

FILE

Gill is a prolific scorer in the IPL. He amassed 650 runs last season, 426 runs the year before

Rohit Sharma, Hardik Pandya and more recently Delhi Capitals' skipper Axar Patel.

In the IPL captains meeting in Mumbai on Wednesday, majority of the leaders including Gill had sought a review of the rule that BCCI introduced in 2023 before extending it at least until 2027.

A day later Gill did not mince his words when asked about his thoughts on the

Impact Player rule, which allows teams to play an extra batter or bowler in any stage of the game.

“Personally for me, I don't think there should be an impact player. I think cricket in general is an 11 players' game and on wickets where we play on the grounds that we play, adding an extra batsman is I think it takes the skill out of the game,” said Gill, who leads India in Tests and ODIs. There's a certain skill in the game that you need to have. When you have a certain amount of batters and if a couple of your batters get out, there's an amount of skill that you need to have to still get the scoreboard moving and get your team to a good score.” AGENCIES

ASIA CUP

Compound archers on target, recurve off mark



Compound archers are leading India's charge at the tournament

BANGKOK: There was no stopping the dominant run of India's compound archers as the top-seeded mixed team pair of Rajat Chauhan and Chikitha Taniparthi stormed into the final but the recurve contingent endured disappointment in the Asia Cup World Ranking Tournament Stage 1, here on Thursday.

For India, two bronze medals are already in the bag, five entries are in the finals, and in addition, the country is in contention for two more bronze medals, keeping them on course to surpass last year's eight-medal haul (five gold, two silver, one bronze).

The compound mixed team duo of Chauhan and Taniparthi, who received a direct entry into the quarterfinals as top seeds, underlined their class with back-to-back wins.

They defeated Chinese Taipei 159-155 in the quarters and then got the better of fourth-seeded Kazakhstan 157-153 in the semifinals. That the Indian pair dropped just four points from a possible 320 across 32 arrows in the two matches underlined their dominance as they assured the country of its sixth medal overall.

However, in the recurve mixed team event, the top-seeded duo of Ruma Biswas and Devanga Gupta suffered a straight-set defeat to Vietnam's Thi Dao Loc and Hoang Phi Vu

For India, two bronze medals are already in the bag, five entries are in the finals

Nguyen in the quarterfinals.

After conceding the opening set 35-37, the Indians improved to 36 in the second but still trailed as the Vietnamese pair edged ahead by a point to take a 4-0 lead. Vietnam then sealed the contest emphatically, dropping just one point in the third set while the Indians managed 37, capping an underwhelming outing for India's recurve contingent.

India's medal surge has been driven by the compound performance, but the recurve archers have failed to live up to expectations. The recurve unit could not defend individual titles and also returned empty-handed from the mixed team event, in which the pair of Vishnu Choudhary and Basanti Mahato had claimed a silver medal in the previous edition.

Overall, India have reached the finals in women's recurve individual, men's recurve team, women's compound team, mixed compound team, and men's compound individual where the country is in line for a clean sweep. AGENCIES

Carolina Marin hangs up racquet

NEW DELHI: One of badminton's all-time greats, Carolina Marin on Thursday announced her retirement due to a persistent knee injury, bringing the curtain down on a glittering career that has an Olympic gold medal and three World Championship titles.

In a video message shared on her social media accounts, captioned “My journey ends here”, the former World No. 1 Spaniard said the recurring injury had forced her to take the difficult call, opting to prioritise her long-term health over a final appearance on court.

“My journey in professional badminton has come to an end and therefore I will not be competing in the European Championships in Huelva,” Marin said. “I wanted us to see each other for the last time on a track, but I don't want to put my body at risk for that. I said many times, and I am consistent with my decision.”

Marin shared one of modern badminton's most compelling rivalries with India's two-time Olympic medallist PV Sindhu, with the duo producing several memorable encounters over the years. AGENCIES

IOC draws the line: Women's events closed to transgender athletes

NEW DELHI: Transgender women athletes are now excluded from women's events at the Olympics after the IOC agreed to a new eligibility policy on Thursday which aligns with U.S. President Donald Trump's executive order on sports ahead of the 2028 Los Angeles Games.

“Eligibility for any female category event at the Olympic Games or any other IOC event, including individual and team sports, is now limited to biological females,” the International Olympic Committee said, to be determined by a mandatory gene test once in an athlete's career.

It is unclear how many, if any, transgender women are competing at an Olympic level. No woman who transitioned from being born male competed at the 2024 Paris Summer Games, though weightlifter Laurel Hubbard did at the Tokyo Olympics in 2021 without winning a medal.

The eligibility policy that will apply from the LA Olympics in July 2028 “protects fairness, safety and integrity in the female category,” the IOC said.

“It is not retroactive and does not apply to any grassroots or recreational sports programs,” said the IOC, whose



Kirsty Coventry, president of the IOC, during the 2026 Winter Olympics

AP

It is unclear how many, if any, transgender women are competing at an Olympic level

Olympic Charter states that access to play sport is a human right.

After an executive board meeting, the International Olympic Committee published a 10-page policy document which also restricts female athletes such as two-time Olympic champion runner Caster Semenya with medical conditions known as differences in sex development, or DSD.

The IOC and its president, Kirsty Coventry, have wanted a clear policy instead of continuing to advise sports governing bodies who previously have drafted their own rules.

“At the Olympic Games, even the smallest margins can be the difference between victory and defeat,” Coventry, a two-time Olympic gold medallist in swimming, said in a statement. “So, it is absolutely clear that it would not be fair for biological males to compete in the female category.” She set up a review of “protecting the female category” as one of her first big decisions last June as the first woman to lead the Olympic body in its 132-year history. AGENCIES

Indian players, head coach denied entry at JLN due to dispute over security deposit

NEW DELHI: Players and the head coach of the Indian men's senior team were on Thursday denied entry at the Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium in Kochi for a press conference over non-payment of a mandatory security deposit to the stadium owners by the Kerala Football Association.

The Indian players, including three from the state, and

head coach Khalid Jamil arrived at the stadium for a pre-match press conference ahead the senior national team's final AFC Asian Cup Qualifiers fixture against Hong Kong on March 31.

However, they were denied entry due to a dispute over the unpaid amount between the The Greater Cochin Development Authority (GCDA),

which owns the stadium, and the Kerala Football Association.

“The issue is that the Kerala FA (football association) was supposed to pay a certain amount to the stadium authorities to block the stadium for four days for the match. That's why the authorities blocked entry,” a source in the All India Football Federation (AIFF) said. AGENCIES

KITG: Triple delight for Manikanta

RAIPUR: Karnataka swimmer Manikanta L completed a hat-trick of gold medals, dominating the 200m individual medley while Odisha's Anjali Munda clinched her second consecutive yellow metal in the women's event on day two of the Khelo India Tribal Games here on Thursday.

Hosts Chhattisgarh also had a reason to rejoice as local hope Anushka Bhagat added a second silver to her tally, finishing second in the women's 200m IM race. Manikanta, who had won the 100m breaststroke and 50m butterfly gold on the opening day, continued to dominate the field as he won the 200m IM race with a time of 2:25.93s. AGENCIES

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr. P.C./84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused **Smt. Beena** W/o Sh. Prem Kumar R/o Flat No. 16/15, MCD Flats, Model Town-3, New Delhi-110033 has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **Case Reg. No. 9953/2019 U/s 138 NI ACT, PS Keshav Puram, Delhi** and it has been returned to warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said accused **Smt. Beena** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Smt. Beena** has absconded (or is concealing herself to avoid the service of said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that **Smt. Beena** in **Case Reg. No. 9953/2019 U/s 138 NI ACT, PS Keshav Puram, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **25.08.2026**.

By order
Shri Sanyam Jain
Judicial Magistrate First Class-04
Room No. 112
Rohini Court, Delhi

Mirabai has ‘unfinished business’ at Asian Games

RAIPUR: Medalling at the Asian Games remains the one milestone Mirabai Chanu is desperate to achieve this year, with the Tokyo Olympics silver-winning weightlifter terming it “unfinished business” in an otherwise illustrious career.

For more than a decade, Chanu has been the face of Indian weightlifting. An Asian Games medal is the only silver-

ware missing from the Manipuri’s decorated cabinet, which includes a Tokyo Olympics silver, three World Championship medals and as many Commonwealth Games podium finishes. “The Asian Games is very important personally because I still have unfinished business there. The competition level is very high, which makes it even more challeng-

ing and exciting,” Chanu said at a press conference following the opening ceremony of the inaugural Khelo India Tribal Games here.

Chanu’s journey in the Asian Games has been marked by near-misses and setbacks. She finished ninth on debut at 2014 Asian Games and was forced to skip the 2018 edition due to a back injury.

The closest she came to a podium finish was in the 2022 Asian Games, where a hip injury derailed Chanu’s campaign at a crucial moment, leaving her just short of a medal. Yashasvi, the youngest of the two, was placed second in the 68th Nationals and also won silver in the junior category at the Asian Championships last year. AGENCIES

Rajasthan United held

JAIPUR: Rajasthan United FC held Diamond Harbour FC to a hard-fought 1-1 draw in the Indian Football League here on Thursday.

Jonathan Fernandes (51’) gave the home side the lead through a penalty and R. Raminthara (82’) equalised for the visitors. Diamond Harbour remained in second place in the table with 10 points, below Sreenidi Deccan FC who also have the same tally. AGENCIES

झारखण्ड सरकार
कार्यपालक अभियंता, का कार्यालय
ग्रामीण विकास विशेष प्रमंडल, पाकुड़

ज्ञापक—...../ग्राविगिप्रप्र, पाकुड़ दिनांक—.....

:- रद्द पत्र :-

इस कार्यालय द्वारा निकाले गए ई-निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना संख्या— RDSPL/PAKUR/24/2025-26 जिसका PR No-370730/2025-26 है का गुप संख्या—06 पाकुड़ जिला के प्रखण्ड अमड़ापाड़ा पंचायत पचुवाड़ा में पचुवाड़ा संकुल स्तरीय महिला प्राथमिक स्वास्थ्य सहायक समिति लिमिटेड के लिए आवासीय संकुल प्रशिक्षण केंद्र का निर्माण कार्य को अपरिहार्य कारणवश रद्द किया जाता है।

कार्यपालक अभियंता,
ग्रामीण विकास विशेष प्रमंडल,
पाकुड़

PR 376172 Rural Work
Department (25-26)_D

PHYSICAL POSSESSION NOTICE

ICICI Bank
Branch office: ICICI Bank Limited Plot No-23, Shal Tower, 3rd Floor, New Rohtak Road, Karol Bagh, New Delhi-110005

The Authorised ICICI Bank Officer under the Securitisation, Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002, issued Demand Notices to the borrower(s) mentioned below, to repay the amount mentioned in the Notice within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said Notice.

Having failed to repay the amount, the Notice is issued to the borrower and the public in general that the undersigned has taken possession of the property described below, by exercising powers conferred on him/her under Section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the said rules on the below-mentioned dates. The borrower in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with the property. Any dealings with the property will be subject to charges of ICICI Bank Limited.

Sr. No.	Name of the Borrower(s)/ Loan Account Number	Description of Property/ Date of Physical Possession	Date of Demand Notice/ Amount in Demand Notice (Rs)	Name of Branch
1.	Anand Pratap Singh/ Aps Infra/ Poonam Singh/ LBNOD00005452632	Flat No. 130, Without Roof Rights, Land Measuring 0-1.1/2 Marle (15 Sq. Yards) Being 1/506 Share of Land Measuring 12 Kanal 13 Marle Comprised In Khewat/ Khatauni No. 325/365, Khasra No. 17/22/1(1-1-2), 22/2(3-11), 23/1(6-14), 23/2(1-6), Situated At Western Tower, Nijihar Road, Sector-126, Greater Mohali, Village Mundi Kharar, Hadbast No. 185, Within Limits of M.C. Kharar, Tehsil Kharar, District S.A.S. Nagar, Mohali, Punjab- 140301. Standing In The Name of M/s A.P.S. Infra Through Its Proprietor Mr. Anand Pratap Singh Vide Sale Deed Wasika No. 2020-21/15/11185, Dated 29/01/2021, 1/ March 24, 2026	August 29, 2025 Rs. 44,73,764.19/-	Mohali Noida

The above-mentioned borrowers(s)/guarantor(s) is/are hereby issued a 30 day Notice to repay the amount, else the mortgaged properties will be sold after 30 days from the date of publishing this Notice, as per the provisions under Rules 8 and 9 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002.

Date: March 27, 2026
Place: Noida

Sincerely Authorised Officer,
For ICICI Bank Ltd.

MADHYA PRADESH ROAD DEVELOPMENT CORPORATION LTD.
(Govt. of M.P. Undertaking)
45-A, Arera Hills, Bhopal – 462 011, Madhya Pradesh
Phone : 0755-2527290/2765205 (EPBX), Fax : 0755-2572643, Website : www.mprdc.gov.in
CIN : U45203MP2004SGC016758

NIT No. 704/MPRDC/Procu/2026

NOTICE INVITING TENDERS

Madhya Pradesh Road Development Corporation Limited (MPRDC) Bhopal invites online tenders for the following works.

S. No.	Name of Work	APC/ PAC Value (in INR Lacs)	Bid Security (EMD) (in INR Lacs)	Cost of Tender Document (i/c GST) (in Rs.)	Period of Services/ Completion
1.	User Fee Collection on Rewa-Beohari-Tetka Road in the State of Madhya Pradesh (2nd Call)	2200.00	110.00	59,000/-	24 Months
2.	Selection of Implementation Agency for Enhancing Capabilities of Existing Accident Response System and Traffic Management Centre under Madhya Pradesh Road Development Corporation (MPRDC) (2nd Call)	850.00	8.50	23,600/-	36 Months
3.	Long term rectification work of 06 Nos. of Black Spot 240, 241, 267, 268, 271 and 272 in Ujjain Division	458.24	4.58	17,700/-	09 Months (including rainy season)
4.	Zonal Work Group-1 for 18 Roads under MPRDC Bhopal & Narmadapuram Division	400.00	4.00	17,700/-	12 Months
5.	Zonal Work Group-2 for 14 Roads under MPRDC Shahdol & Chhindwara Divisions)	400.00	4.00	17,700/-	12 Months
6.	Maintenance work of Jabalpur - Hiran River section of NH-12 from existing km. 11/4 to 66/4 (design chainage 104+000 to 664+000) in the State of Madhya Pradesh to four lanes with paved shoulders under NHDP-III on EPC mode on the risk and cost of the EPC contractor (2nd Call)	313.38	3.13	17,700/-	08 Months (including rainy season)
7.	Zonal Work Group-3 for 16 Roads under MPRDC Sagar Division	200.00	2.00	14,750/-	12 Months
8.	Zonal Work Group-4 for 22 Roads under MPRDC Gwalior Division	200.00	2.00	14,750/-	12 Months
9.	Zonal Work Group-5 for 14 Roads under MPRDC Ujjain Division	200.00	2.00	14,750/-	12 Months
10.	Long term rectification work of 4 Nos. of Black Spot 163, 230, 231 and 233 in Dhar Division.	187.93	1.88	14,750/-	09 Months (including rainy season)
11.	Long term rectification work of 04 Black Spot 51, 53, 54 & 336 in Narmadapuram Division.	145.38	1.45	14,750/-	09 Months (including rainy season)
12.	Long term rectification work of 03 Black Spot 206, 210 and 216 in Indore Division.	139.83	1.40	14,750/-	09 Months (including rainy season)
13.	Consultancy Services for the Preparation of Feasibility/DP/ Report For Two/Four Lining With Paved Shoulder of Selected Stretches of Major District Roads Package-I (Length - 1146.030 Km)	-	2.00	23,600/-	12 Months

The dates for purchase, submission, etc. are mentioned in the key dates. Tender forms can be purchased online only upto 15:30 hrs. on 28.04.2026 for Sr. No. 01, 02 & 06 and 06.05.2026 for Sr. No. 03 to 05 & 07 to 13 from website www.mptenders.gov.in. The bidders have to submit the Technical bid as well as Financial Bid online (if any) shall only be published on the website of www.mptenders.gov.in only. If holiday is declared by Govt. of M.P. on the date of opening, the same will automatically be shifted to subsequent working days.

MPRDC reserves the right to accept/reject any/all tenders without assigning any reason thereof.

M.P. Madhyam/125085/2026

MANAGING DIRECTOR

WEST CENTRAL RAILWAY
Notice Inviting E-Tender

E-Tenders are invited from reputed, experienced, contractors Qualifies Minimum Eligibility Criteria and having Electrical Contractor license by Chief Workshop Manager Coach Rehabilitation Workshop West Central Railway Nishatpura Bhopal for and on behalf of President of India for the under mentioned works:-

SI.No.:01, Tender Notice No.: WCR-CRWS-BPL-EL-T-2025-13 Date: 20.03.2026, Name of work: "Electrical modification work in LHB NON AC & LHB AC coaches during POH schedule at CRWS Bhopal at CRWS/BPL for period of two years", Cost of work: ₹ 3,12,31,377.77, Bid Security: ₹ 3,06,200.00, Cost of Tender form: ₹ 0.00, Bidding System: Single Packet System, Completion period of work: 24 Months, Tender Closing Date: 17.04.2026 : upto 15:00 Hrs. Tender Opening Date: 17.04.2026 After 15:00 hrs. Note: Detailed information about tender and tender format is available at Govt. Of India website www.irops.gov.in. Tender notice is available at notice board of the office of Chief Workshop Manager, (Electrical Branch) Coach Rehabilitation Workshop, Nishatpura, Bhopal

Works Manager (Electrical)
WCR, CRWS/Bhopal

सबसे भारत अभियान
एक कदम स्वच्छता की ओर

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY
E-TENDER NOTICE

The Deputy Chief Project Manager/Gati Shakti/East Central Railway/Samastipur, on behalf of the President of India, invite open e-tenders on IREPS web portal from experienced and financially capable tenderers for the following works:

SI.No. : 1, Tender Notice No. : PSSA-GSU-SPJ-2025-26, Name of work: Appointment of Project Supervision Services Agency (PSSA) for Providing project supervision services for works being executed under Gati Shakti Unit / Samastipur at 20 stations namely Laheriasarai (LSI), Madhubani (MBI), Sakri (SKI), Janakpur Road (JNR), Jaynagar (JYG), Sagauli (SGL), Narkatiaganj (NKE), Bettiah (BTH), Raxaul (RLX), Ghorasahan (GRH), Salsaula (SLNA), Samastipur (SPJ), Banmankhi (BNKI), Simri Bakhtiyarpur (SBK), Supaul (SUP), Saharsa (SHC), Dauram Madhepura (DMH), Chakia (CAA), Motipur (MTR) & Jhanjharpur (JJP) railway stations of SPJ Division., Tender Cost (Rs.) : ₹ 43376701.20, Earnest Money (Rs.) : ₹ 366900.00, Completion Period : 24 Months, 1. Last date and time for submission of e-tender on IREPS portal : 15.04.2026 up to 12:00 hrs. 2. Date of opening of e-tender :- 01.04.2026 3. Detailed information can be obtained from website : www.irops.gov.in. Any corrigendum / amendment related to this tender will not be published in newspapers but will be uploaded on the website only.

Dy. CPM/Gati Shakti
E.C.Railway/Samastipur
PR/1989/SPJ/GS/T/25-26/48

ICICI Bank

Branch Office: ICICI Bank Limited Plot No-23, Shal Tower, 3rd Floor, New Rohtak Road, Karol Bagh, New Delhi- 110005

The following borrower(s) has/have defaulted in the repayment of principal and interest towards the Loan facility(ies) availed from ICICI Bank. The Loan(s) has/have been classified as Non-Performing Asset(s) (NPA). A Notice was issued to them under Section 13(2) of the Securitisation and Re-construction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002, at their last known addresses. However, it has not been served and are therefore being notified by way of this Public Notice.

Sr. No.	Name of the Borrower/ Co-Borrower/ Guarantor/ (Loan Account Number) & Address	Description of Secured Asset to be enforced	Date of Notice sent/ Outstanding as on Date of Notice	NPA Date
1.	Yashvir Hooda/ News Paper EMP CGHS Sec 19 Dwarika Flat No. A-201, Plot No. 1 South West Delhi Delhi South West Delhi- 110075/ TBROH00006590805	Plot No. 76, A One Homes, Sector 27A, VPO Kheri Sadh, Rohtak, Haryana- 124021	10/03/2026 Rs. 12,65,649.48/-	03/ Jan/ 2026
2.	Vertika Khurana/ Ayushi Khurana/ Tesla Power Use Inc/ S 1001 Bestech Park View Signature Spa, Sector 81 Gurgaon Haryana Gurgaon- 122001/ LBGUR00006224549	Commercial Office Premise Bearing No. DCG1-1012 On 10th Floor In Tower 1, With One Car Parking Space No. PB/T1-3140, DLF Corporate Greens, Sector 74A, Tehsil Kadipur, Village Begampur Khatola And Narsinghpur, Gurgaon, Haryana- 122004	13/03/2026 Rs. 56,46,961/-	11/ Dec/ 2025
3.	Chhotan Yadav/ Munni Kumari/ Aakera 292 Dharuhera Haryana Gurgaon- 123106/ LBGUR00006890555	Plot No. F 162, Group Housing Complex, Anandam Awaas, Dharuhera, Sector 19, Village Garhi Alwalpur, Sub Tehsil Dharuheradist Rewari, Haryana- 123106	10/03/2026 Rs. 2,38,375/-	06/ Oct/ 2025
4.	Chhotan Yadav/ Munni Kumari/ Aakera 292 Dharuhera Haryana Gurgaon- 123106/ TBGUR00006790824	Plot No. F 162, Group Housing Complex, Anandam Awaas, Dharuhera, Sector 19, Village Garhi Alwalpur, Sub Tehsil Dharuheradist Rewari, Haryana- 123106	10/03/2026 Rs. 71,79,661/-	06/ Oct/ 2025
5.	Renu Kathuria/ Rajiv Kathuria/ Tai Infotech Pvt Ltd/ 600 Near Huda Market, Sec 31 Gurgaon Haryana Gurgaon- 122001/ LBGUR00003300349	Plot No. 10 Ground Floor Block D, Sector 48, Residential Colony Vipul World Village Fazilpur Jharoa And Tikri, Tehsil And District Gurgaon Haryana- 122001	14/03/2026 Rs. 1,69,45,158.22/-	03/ Feb/ 2026

These steps are being taken for substituted service of Notice. The above borrower(s) and/or guarantor(s) (as applicable) is/are advised to make the outstanding payment within 60 days from the date of publishing this Notice. Else, further steps will be taken as per the provisions of the Securitisation and Re-construction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002.

Date: March 27, 2026
Place: Delhi/ Ncr

Sincerely Authorised Officer,
For ICICI Bank Ltd.

ICICI Bank

Branch Office: ICICI Bank Limited Plot No-23, Shal Tower, 3rd Floor, New Rohtak Road, Karol Bagh, New Delhi- 110005

The following borrower(s) has/have defaulted in the repayment of principal and interest towards the Loan facility(ies) availed from ICICI Bank. The Loan(s) has/have been classified as Non-Performing Asset(s) (NPA). A Notice was issued to them under Section 13(2) of the Securitisation and Re-construction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002, at their last known addresses. However, it has not been served and are therefore being notified by way of this Public Notice.

Sr. No.	Name of the Borrower/ Co-Borrower/ Guarantor/ (Loan Account Number) & Address	Description of Secured Asset to be enforced	Date of Notice sent/ Outstanding as on Date of Notice	NPA Date
1.	Aman Srivastava/ Seema Srivastava (LBKAN00007236155) & 736, C Block, Cod, Kanpur Nagar, Uttar Pradesh Kanpur Nagar- 208013	Property Comprised On Part Of Plot No-36, Aarazi No- 832 Min, Situated At Mauja Daheli Sujampur, Pargana And District- Kanpur Nagar, Uttar Pradesh Kanpur Nagar 208015	26/02/2026/ Rs. 95,613/-	03/01/ 2026
2.	Aman Srivastava/ Seema Srivastava (TBKAN00007230196) & 736, C Block, Cod, Kanpur Nagar, Uttar Pradesh Kanpur Nagar- 208013	Property Comprised On Part Of Plot No-36, Aarazi No- 832 Min, Situated At Mauja Daheli Sujampur, Pargana And District- Kanpur Nagar, Uttar Pradesh Kanpur Nagar 208015	26/02/2026/ Rs. 48,34,284.99/-	03/01/ 2026
3.	Rahul Uniyal/ Indresh Charan Uniyal (LBDEH00002418443) & A-405 Shramdeep Apartment, Plot No-FLR B9/1B Sector 62, Near Sector 62 B Block Market, Uttar Pradesh Noida- 201307	Unit Bearing No-318 (without Roof Rights) 3rd Floor, Situated At Times Square Mall, Constructed Over Khasra No-308, 309 Ga, 309 Kha, 310, Sahasradhara Road, Vill- adhoiwala, Pargana Parvadaon, Dist- dehradun, Uttarakhand 248001	09/03/2026/ Rs. 8,74,692.81/-	03/01/ 2026

These steps are being taken for substituted service of Notice. The above borrower(s) and/or guarantor(s) (as applicable) is/are advised to make the outstanding payment within 60 days from the date of publishing this Notice. Else, further steps will be taken as per the provisions of the Securitisation and Re-construction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002.

Date: March 27, 2026
Place: Delhi/NCR

Sincerely Authorised Officer
For ICICI Bank Ltd.

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 CrPC/84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Babu S/o Shri Sukhdev R/o Himmat Garh Chowk, Near Ram Lila Ground, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case registered vide FIR No. 012318/2024 U/S 379/411/34 IPC, PS Barakhamba Road, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest their upon issued that the said accused Babu can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said Babu has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused Babu of FIR No. 012318/2024 U/S 379/411/34 IPC, PS Barakhamba Road, Delhi is required to appear before this court (or before me) to answer the complaint on or before the day of 30.04.2026

By Order,
Ms. Vijayshree Rathore
Judicial Magistrate First Class-05
Court No. 13, First Floor, Main Building
DP/3895/NDD/2026 (Court Matter) Patiala House Court, New Delhi

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY
NIT No. TMC/CPOH/PRYJ/25-26/10 Date : 24.03.2026

E-TENDER NOTICE

Dy. CE / CPOH/ Workshop / North Central Railway / Prayagraj for and on behalf of the President of India, invites "Open" E-Tender on prescribed form for the following work upto 15:00 hrs on 20.04.2026. The details of the Tender are as under:-

Tender No. : TMC-CPOH-PRYJ-15-25-26

Name of work : Supply, installation and commissioning of universal hydraulic test bench for testing of hydraulic pumps, motors, cylinders, valves including proportional & servo valve as per scope of work in CPOH, Workshop, Prayagraj.

Approx. Cost (Rs.) : 15222000.00 Earnest Money (Rs.) : 226100.00

Cost of Tender Form (Rs.) : NIL Completion Period : 09 Month

Date of Opening of tender : 20.04.2026

Similar Work for Eligibility Criteria : OEM of Track machines or their authorized dealers or OEM of hydraulic pumps, motors, valves and cylinders being used over IR network on Track machines.

Note:- (1) The complete information along with tender document of above E-Tenders are available on Website www.irops.gov.in up to 15:00 hrs, on the due date of tender opening. (2) Bids other than in the form of E-Bids shall not be accepted against above tenders. For this purpose, vendors are required to get themselves registered with IREPS website along with Digital Signature Certificate issued by CCA under IT Act-2000. (3) Rates entered into Financial Rate page and duly signed digitally shall be considered. Rates and any other financial entity in any other form/ letter head, if attached by vendors shall be straightway ignored and shall not be considered. (4) The supplier / Contractor of goods and / or services would be subject to GST Act and Rules as applicable from time to time. (5) Document being attached should be signed by the tenderer on its body. (6) This tender notice has also been uploaded on www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in. (7) Payment of Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) in respect of e-tendering shall be accepted through net banking or payment gateway only or as per provision stipulated in applicable GCE. (8) In case of any difficulty, helpdesk available on the website of IREPS may be approached. (9) Tender online can be submitted upto 15:00 hrs on 20.04.2026. (10) Due to administrative reasons NIT NO. TMC-CPOH-PRYJ-14-25-26 of the same work which was scheduled to be opened on 02.04.2026 has been cancelled. 668/26 (AS)

North central railways @ www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in @ CPRONCR

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita-2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Inderjeet Singh, S/o Atoar Singh, R/o E-54, Nihal Vihar, Niloti, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case FIR No. 032742/2022, U/s 379/411 IPC, P.S. Keshav Puram, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said Inderjeet Singh cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said Inderjeet Singh has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said Inderjeet Singh accused of FIR No. 032742/2022, U/s 379/411 IPC, P.S. Keshav Puram, Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 06.08.2026.

By Order - Sanyam Jain
Judicial Magistrate First Class-04
North-West, Room No. 112
Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/3861/NW/2026

PUBLIC NOTICE

Branch Office: ICICI Bank Limited Plot No-23, Shal Tower, 3rd Floor, New Rohtak Road, Karol Bagh, New Delhi- 110005

The following borrower(s) has/have defaulted in the repayment of principal and interest towards the Loan facility(ies) availed from ICICI Bank. The Loan(s) has/have been classified as Non-Performing Asset(s) (NPA). A Notice was issued to them under Section 13(2) of the Securitisation and Re-construction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002, at their last known addresses. However, it has not been served and are therefore being notified by way of this Public Notice.

Sr. No.	Name of the Borrower/ Co-Borrower/ Guarantor/ (Loan Account Number) & Address	Description of Secured Asset to be enforced	Date of Notice sent/ Outstanding as on Date of Notice	NPA Date
1.	Yashvir Hooda/ News Paper EMP CGHS Sec 19 Dwarika Flat No. A-201, Plot No. 1 South West Delhi Delhi South West Delhi- 110075/ TBROH00006590805	Plot No. 76, A One Homes, Sector 27A, VPO Kheri Sadh, Rohtak, Haryana- 124021	10/03/2026 Rs. 12,65,649.48/-	03/ Jan/ 2026
2.	Vertika Khurana/ Ayushi Khurana/ Tesla Power Use Inc/ S 1001 Bestech Park View Signature Spa, Sector 81 Gurgaon Haryana Gurgaon- 122001/ LBGUR00006224549	Commercial Office Premise Bearing No. DCG1-1012 On 10th Floor In Tower 1, With One Car Parking Space No. PB/T1-3140, DLF Corporate Greens, Sector 74A, Tehsil Kadipur, Village Begampur Khatola And Narsinghpur, Gurgaon, Haryana- 122004	13/03/2026 Rs. 56,46,961/-	11/ Dec/ 2025
3.	Chhotan Yadav/ Munni Kumari/ Aakera 292 Dharuhera Haryana Gurgaon- 123106/ LBGUR00006890555	Plot No. F 162, Group Housing Complex, Anandam Awaas, Dharuhera, Sector 19, Village Garhi Alwalpur, Sub Tehsil Dharuheradist Rewari, Haryana- 123106	10/03/2026 Rs. 2,38,375/-	06/ Oct/ 2025
4.	Chhotan Yadav/ Munni Kumari/ Aakera 292 Dharuhera Haryana Gurgaon- 123106/ TBGUR00006790824	Plot No. F 162, Group Housing Complex, Anandam Awaas, Dharuhera, Sector 19, Village Garhi Alwalpur, Sub Tehsil Dharuheradist Rewari, Haryana- 123106	10/03/2026 Rs. 71,79,661/-	06/ Oct/ 2025
5.	Renu Kathuria/ Rajiv Kathuria/ Tai Infotech Pvt Ltd/ 600 Near Huda Market, Sec 31 Gurgaon Haryana Gurgaon- 122001/ LBGUR00003300349	Plot No. 10 Ground Floor Block D, Sector 48, Residential Colony Vipul World Village Fazilpur Jharoa And Tikri, Tehsil And District Gurgaon Haryana- 122001	14/03/2026 Rs. 1,69,45,158.22/-	03/ Feb/ 2026

These steps are being taken for substituted service of Notice. The above borrower(s) and/or guarantor(s) (as applicable) is/are advised to make the outstanding payment within 60 days from the date of publishing this Notice. Else, further steps will be taken as per the provisions of the Securitisation and Re-construction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002.

Date: March 27, 2026
Place: Delhi/ Ncr

Sincerely Authorised Officer,
For ICICI Bank Ltd.

PUBLIC NOTICE

Branch Office: ICICI Bank Limited Plot No-23, Shal Tower, 3rd Floor, New Rohtak Road, Karol Bagh, New Delhi- 110005

The following borrower(s) has/have defaulted in the repayment of principal and interest towards the Loan facility(ies) availed from ICICI Bank. The Loan(s) has/have been classified as Non-Performing Asset(s) (NPA). A Notice was issued to them under Section 13(2) of the Securitisation and Re-construction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002, at their last known addresses. However, it has not been served and are therefore being notified by way of this Public Notice.

Sr. No.	Name of the Borrower/ Co-Borrower/ Guarantor/ (Loan Account Number) & Address	Description of Secured Asset to be enforced	Date of Notice sent/ Outstanding as on Date of Notice	NPA Date
1.	Aman Srivastava/ Seema Srivastava (LBKAN00007236155) & 736, C Block, Cod, Kanpur Nagar, Uttar Pradesh Kanpur Nagar- 208013	Property Comprised On Part Of Plot No-36, Aarazi No- 832 Min, Situated At Mauja Daheli Sujampur, Pargana And District- Kanpur Nagar, Uttar Pradesh Kanpur Nagar 208015	26/02/2026/ Rs. 95,613/-	03/01/ 2026
2.	Aman Srivastava/ Seema Srivastava (TBKAN00007230196) & 736, C Block, Cod, Kanpur Nagar, Uttar Pradesh Kanpur Nagar- 208013	Property Comprised On Part Of Plot No-36, Aarazi No- 832 Min, Situated At Mauja Daheli Sujampur, Pargana And District- Kanpur Nagar, Uttar Pradesh Kanpur Nagar 208015	26/02/2026/ Rs. 48,34,284.99/-	03/01/ 2026
3.	Rahul Uniyal/ Indresh Charan Uniyal (LBDEH00002418443) & A-405 Shramdeep Apartment, Plot No-FLR B9/1B Sector 62, Near Sector 62 B Block Market, Uttar Pradesh Noida- 201307	Unit Bearing No-318 (without Roof Rights) 3rd Floor, Situated At Times Square Mall, Constructed Over Khasra No-308, 309 Ga, 309 Kha, 310, Sahasradhara Road, Vill- adhoiwala, Pargana Parvadaon, Dist- dehradun, Uttarakhand 248001	09/03/2026/ Rs. 8,74,692.81/-	03/01/ 2026

These steps are being taken for substituted service of Notice. The above borrower(s) and/or guarantor(s) (as applicable) is/are advised to make the outstanding payment within 60 days from the date of publishing this Notice. Else, further steps will be taken as per the provisions of the Securitisation and Re-construction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002.

Date: March 27, 2026
Place: Delhi/NCR

Sincerely Authorised Officer
For ICICI Bank Ltd.

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED

(See Section 82 Cr. PC/)

(84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita-2023)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person namely Sunil Paswan S/o Nussal Paswan R/o Near Transport Mundka and Permanent Address Gaon: Nikampur, Nazi Gunj, Tehsil: Akha Vishnupur, Distt: Samastipur Bihar has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case FIR No. 563/2021 U/s 33 Delhi Excise Act at P.S.: Mundka, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said accused Sunil Paswan could not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused Sunil Paswan has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person Sunil Paswan of case FIR No. 563/2021 U/s 33 Delhi Excise Act of P.S.: Mundka, Delhi is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before 30.04.2026.

By order
Gaurav Singal
Judicial Magistrate First Class-06
West Room No.355
Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

DP/3769/OD/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr. PC./84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Himanshu, S/o Kamlesh R/o N-17/C-238, F-Block, J.J. Colony, Wazirpur, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case FIR. No.006858/2023 u/s 379/411 IPC, P.S. Keshav Puram, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused Himanshu cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused Himanshu has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused Himanshu of FIR. No.006858/2023 u/s 379/411 IPC, P.S. Keshav Puram, Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 02.09.2026.

By Order,
Sh. Sanyam Jain
Judicial Magistrate First Class-04, (North-West)
Room No.112, Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/3858/NW/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr. P.C./84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused Sukhpreet Singh S/o Surjeet Singh R/o D-17, 3rd Floor, 301 Harijan Basti, near B-9, Gate 3, Masoodpur, New Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in FIR No. 100/25,97/25,98/25,99/25 Dated 24.02.2025 U/s 420/406 IPC, PS Vasant Kunj North, Delhi and it has been returned to warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said accused Sukhpreet Singh cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused Sukhpreet Singh has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that Sukhpreet Singh in FIR No. 100/25,97/25,98/25,99/25 Dated 24.02.2025 U/s 420/406 IPC, PS Vasant Kunj North, Delhi is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before 30.04.2026.

By order
Shri Animesh Kumar
Judicial Magistrate First Class
Room No. 32, Lok-Up Building
Patiala House Courts, New Delhi

DP/3522/SW/2026

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY
E-TENDERING TENDER NOTICE

Divisional Railway Manager (Works) N.C. Railway, Jhansi for and behalf of President of India invites sealed "Open Tender" through on Line (E-Tendering) for the following work.

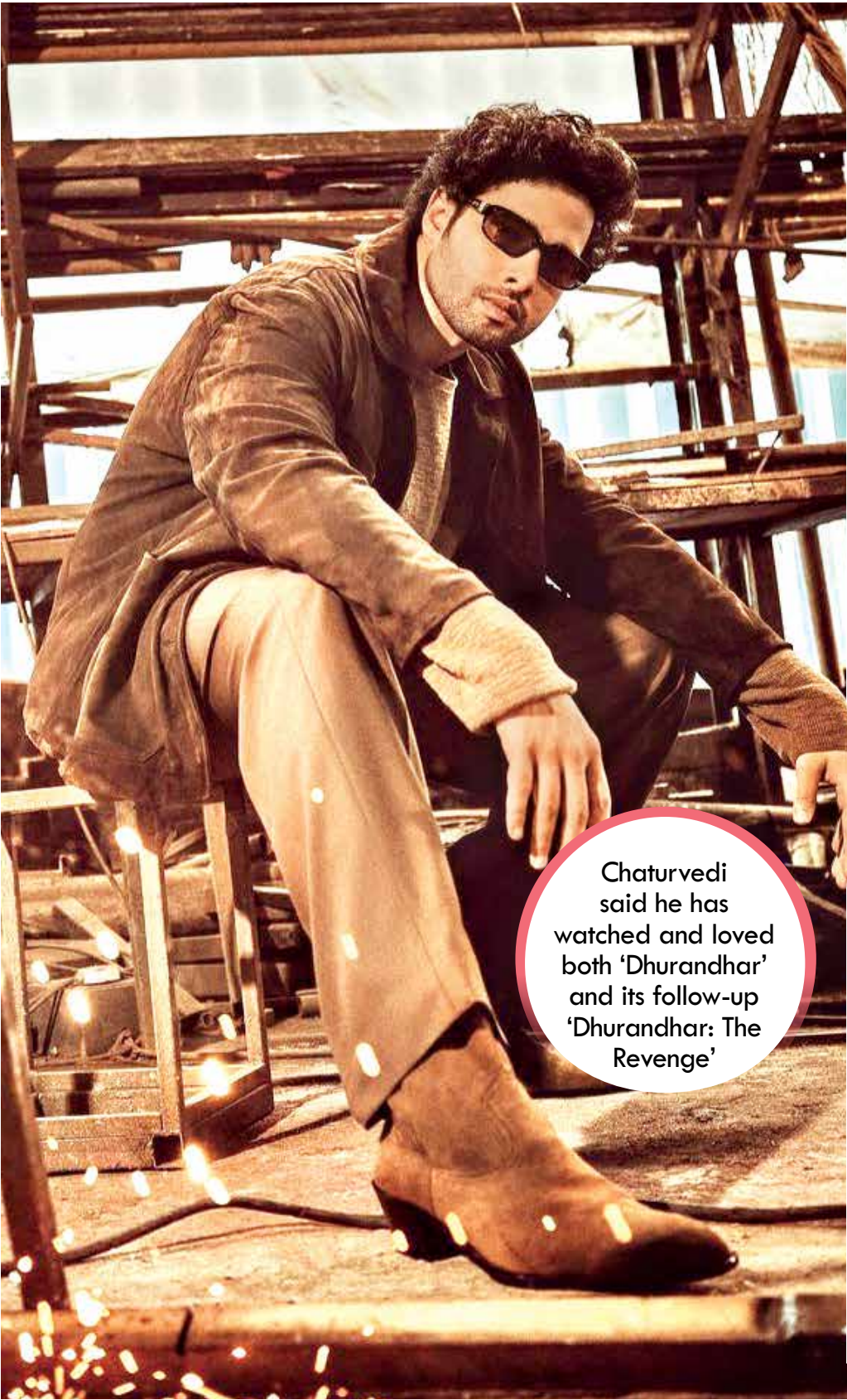
E-Tender No.	Approx Cost	Earnest Money
JHS-ENGG-N-2026-55	166872905.50	3337500.00

Description of work: Balance work for- Jhansi Division: VGLJ-STLI section: Providing and erecting "W" metal cattle barrier along the track to prevent CRO in remaining portion under ADEN/Line/JHS sub division.

Date of closing Tender: 16.04.2026 at 15:00 hrs.

Date of completion/period from issue acceptance letter : 05 Months

• Tender online can be submitted upto 15:00 hrs on 16.04.2026. • For full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Rail



'WAS SURPRISED BY RANVEER IN DHURANDHAR'

Siddhant Chaturvedi praised Singh for his performance in the two-part espionage saga

Siddhant Chaturvedi, who praised 'Gully Boy' co-star Ranveer Singh for his performance in the two-part espionage saga 'Dhurandhar', said he was surprised by the actor's turn as a spy in the movie.

At the red carpet of the inaugural International Film Festival of Delhi (IFFD) in New Delhi, Chaturvedi said he has watched and loved both 'Dhurandhar' and its follow-up 'Dhurandhar: The Revenge'.

"I have seen him closely performing and every time I watch that man on screen, it's always surprising. When I watched 'Dhurandhar' - both the parts - I was still surprised because the process, the depth, the nuances and the aggression and even though I know him so closely, it's always surprising and that's the mark of a true actor," the actor told PTI.

'Dhurandhar: The Revenge' was released on March 19 and has already crossed the mark of Rs 900 crore at the global box office, according to industry tracking site 'Sacnilk'.

Featuring Ranveer in the lead role, the film is a follow-up to Dhar's 2025 release 'Dhurandhar', which went on



to earn over Rs 1,000 crore at the box office worldwide. The sequel charts the rise of Singh's character Hamza Ali Mazari in the Karachi underworld while also delving into his origins as Jaskirat Singh Rangji, tracing the journey of the young man who eventually transforms into the covert operative.

The International Film Festival of Delhi (IFFD) 2026 will screen 140 films from 47 countries across multiple venues in the national capital. The festival will open at Bharat Mandapam with a red carpet ceremony and a gala screening of the Oscar-nominated film 'Sirat'.

The film gala is organised by the Delhi Tourism and Transportation Development Corporation (DTTDC) in association with the Delhi government. PTI

Chaturvedi said he has watched and loved both 'Dhurandhar' and its follow-up 'Dhurandhar: The Revenge'

BTS reunion concert gets 18.4 million viewers on Netflix



The OTT streamer confirmed the figures through its official account on 'X'

When BTS walked onto a stage at Gwanghwamun Square in central Seoul on the night of March 21, the world showed up. Millions of them, across time zones, on screens large and small, all waiting for the same moment that ARMY had been counting down to for nearly four years.

'Netflix' confirmed the figures through its official account on 'X', announcing: "18.4 million global viewers (Live+1) showed up for their BANGTAN when BTS reunited LIVE onstage for the first time in almost four years in BTS THE COMEBACK LIVE [ARI-RANG! Congratulations to RM, Jin, SUGA, J-hope, Jimin, V and Jung Kook on their iconic performance." The figure combined real-time audiences and those who watched within 24 hours of the broadcast, according to 'Netflix'.

That wasn't where it stopped. The concert also scored 13.1 million views for the week ending March 22, placing it at number one on Netflix's non-English TV list and in fact, leading all of television on the streamer that week. 'Netflix' calculates its weekly views

by dividing total viewing hours by the runtime of the title. With a runtime of one hour and six minutes and 1.31 crore views generating 1.44 crore hours watched, the scale of engagement becomes even clearer.

The show ranked first in 24 countries and entered the weekly top 10 in 80 regions worldwide

The show ranked first in 24 countries and entered the weekly top 10 in 80 regions worldwide. Countries where it topped the charts included South Korea, Mexico, Japan, the Philippines, Indonesia and Bulgaria.

The comeback performance was staged at Gwanghwamun Square in central Seoul. Over 200,000 fans attended the event in person in central Seoul, while tens of millions more watched on 'Netflix' from across the globe. The concert marked the release of the group's fifth studio album, also titled 'Arirang'. AGENCIES

FABRICATED IMAGES IN DHURANDHAR 2

'Images of Ranveer smoking while wearing turban fabricated'

Filmmaker Aditya Dhar said the images of Ranveer Singh's character smoking while wearing a turban are 'completely untrue' and 'fabricated to create mischief'.

Dhar also warned that such manipulation of the images will be 'dealt with firmly'.

The filmmaker, who is basking in the glory of the film's massive success on the big screen, said he is grateful and indebted to the overwhelming love that 'Dhurandhar: The Revenge', the second part of his espionage saga, has received from audiences across the country and the world.

Filmmaker Aditya Dhar also warned that such manipulation of the images will be 'dealt with firmly'



"However, it has come to my attention that certain individuals are circulating manipulated visuals by morphing officially released promotional material using artificial intelligence to create false and misleading narratives. One such fabricated image falsely depicts the character Hamza/Jaskirat smoking while wearing a turban. This is completely untrue and does not form part of the film or any official material released by us. It is a deliberate act of misrepresentation intended to provoke and create mischief," Dhar said.

The filmmaker's statement comes after a police complaint was filed against the makers and the actor for the image, which shows Ranveer Singh's character smoking while wearing a turban.

Dhar stated that he wanted to make it 'unequivocally' that he holds the highest respect for the Sikh community. "And

every portrayal in the film has been handled with utmost sensitivity, dignity and responsibility. Any attempt to suggest otherwise through any doctored content is malicious and dishonest. I urge audiences to rely only on official content and watch the film as it is intended and not fall prey to AI-generated misinformation being circulated with ulterior motives," he said.

A Mumbai-based Sikh organisation had objected to the images of Ranveer's character recites verses from Guru Granth Sahib, which they said happens while he is smoking.

Madhavan issued a clarification to say that Dhar was very careful during the filming of the scene and his character puts out the cigarette before saying those lines. PTI

'I'm doing films just for the love of craft now'

Vivek Oberoi, who is set to feature in filmmaker Sandeep Reddy Vanga's next movie 'Spirit', said he is doing films purely for the love of acting these days and doesn't take any kind of pressure.

The actor will feature alongside Prabhas and Triptii Dimri in the movie being directed by Vanga, best known for blockbusters 'Arjun Reddy', 'Kabir Singh' and 'Animal'.

Vivek Oberoi is set to feature in filmmaker Sandeep Reddy Vanga's next movie 'Spirit'

Asked if he believes 'Spirit' will do wonders for him just 'Animal' did for Bobby Deol and 'Dhurandhar' did for Akshaye Khanna, Oberoi said, "Picture abhi baaki hai mere dost. I have to do a lot of work and do my best. Rest is up to God."

"Nowadays, I



do films just for my passion and I'm enjoying that a lot. If I get a good script and a good role, I find joy in acting without any pressure. I'm doing it just for the love of the craft," he added.

'Spirit', produced by Vanga under his production banner 'Bhadrakali Pictures', is currently scheduled for release on March 5, 2027. PTI

A NETFLIX PSYCHOLOGICAL DRAMA

Adam Sandler to star in 'Time Out'

Hollywood star Adam Sandler is set to headline 'Time Out', a remake of the acclaimed French psychological drama 'L'Emploi Du Temps', for streaming service 'Netflix'.

According to 'Variety', Christian Bale had been circling the project before Sandler came on board.

The movie is to be written and directed by Scott Cooper, known for movies such as 'Crazy Heart', 'Out of the Furnace', 'Black Mass', 'Hostiles' and 'The Pale Blue Eye'. He will also produce the film.

Sandler will lead an ensemble cast that includes Oscar nominee Willem Dafoe, Oscar winner F Murray Abraham, Gaby Hoffmann, Steve Zahn, and Adam Horowitz.

The original 2001 French film, directed by Laurent Cantet and co-written by Robin Campillo, follows a man who is fired from his job but

cannot bring himself to admit it to his wife and family. To conceal his unemployment, he resorts to increasingly elaborate lies, eventually concocting an investment scheme and soliciting funds from friends.

The casting shows a shift for Sandler from his usual comedy roles, though he has often mixed popular films with more serious performances during his time with 'Netflix'.

His work on the platform includes comedies like 'Murder Mystery' and 'Happy Gilmore 2', as well as more understated dramas such as 'The Meyerowitz Stories' and 2025's 'Jay Kelly', co-starring George Clooney.

Cooper's most recent film was 'Springsteen: Deliver Me from Nowhere', a biographical drama about the making of Bruce Springsteen's album 'Nebraska'. PTI



According to 'Variety', Christian Bale had been circling the project before Sandler came on board

OF BONDS & FRIENDSHIPS

Nana Patekar talks about Prakash Jha

The actor also shared about the behind-the-scenes of 'Sankalp'

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Amazon MX Player recently launched 'Sankalp', a gripping socio-political thriller that delves into the layered world of power, mentorship and ideology.

Directed by National Award-Winning filmmaker Prakash Jha and produced by 'PJP Productions' in partnership with 'Jio Studios', the series is headlined by Nana Patekar alongside a powerhouse cast featuring Mohammed Zeeshan Ayyub, Kubbra Sait, Neeraj Kabi, Sanjay Kapoor and Kranti Prakash Jha in pivotal roles.

As the show sparks conversation, Nana Patekar reflected on the intangible energy that shaped the experience behind the scenes.

Opening up about his time on set, the veteran actor shared,



"Mein sach kehta hu woh kya hota hai ke shaam ko aap jaake khaana banao, sab unit saatme betha hai gappe maar rahe hai aur kha rahe hai. Toh woh jo ek bond band jaata hai na, toh woh set pe badi aasani ho jaati hai. Logon ko lagta hai sirf khaana bana hai. Khaana nahi banta sirf, woh family ban jaati hai (I'm telling you the truth - what happens is that in the evening, you go and cook dinner and the entire unit sits together - chatting, laughing and eating. So, that bond that forms - it makes

'Once you get to know each other's good and bad points - that's when a friendship is formed,' says Patekar about his friendship with the filmmaker

things on the set much easier. People think that it is merely food being prepared. But it isn't just food that is being made - a family is being built."

Further adding to his friendship with Prakash Jha, he said, "Once you get to know each other's good and bad points - that's when a friendship is formed. I don't dwell on the fact that you have this flaw; he has accepted me exactly as I am. With all the flaws I have, things become remarkably easy with him."